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Culture mechanics

culture mechanics *noun*

Status: proposed theoretical term

Field: moral psychology (psychology of morality), social psychology, cultural psychology, organizational psychology, organization studies, sociology of morality, sociology of culture, cultural theory, distributed cognition

Short definition

Culture mechanics is a proposed framework for explaining how culture is installed in people, activated in particular situations, synchronized across groups, reproduced through institutions, and deliberately or accidentally changed.

It describes the human being as **homo duplex**, a creature with two functionally distinct processing units. The first is a powerful, general-purpose processor: the brain's main CPU. The second is a simpler social and affective processor called the **bigOther**. The bigOther does not reason in detail. It classifies thoughts, persons, actions, and situations by attaching culturally learned sentiments to them: honour or shame, loyalty or betrayal, sacredness or pollution, legitimacy or illegitimacy, belonging or exclusion.

Although the bigOther is comparatively primitive, it is connected at a decisive point. By changing how a person *feels* about what the main processor is thinking, it can redirect attention, motivation, judgment, and action before conscious reasoning notices what has happened. It is programmed slowly with a **mythological lens** and activated quickly by social signals. In terminology adapted from Systems Leadership, a **mythology** is one socially evaluated narrative or story. Many mythologies, reinforced by symbols, rituals, institutional practices, rewards, punishments, and exemplary behaviour, shape the lens through which the bigOther maps real-world observations and events onto culturally learned values and feelings.

The **single-slot principle** proposes one local bigOther executing one operative mythological lens. That lens may braid several compatible cultural packages into a complex program; it is not a hierarchy of parallel bigOthers. An incompatible governing worldview must be rejected, or the incumbent weave must be unbraided sufficiently for one successor to be rebraided and installed.

Stable installation means **complete slot occupancy** or, in a neutral architectural sense, **full capture**. A first-order program and a lifted second-order meta-program can each fully occupy the one slot. A lifted program does not govern less. The order-level distinction concerns what is shared: first-order mechanical solidarity shares concrete rules and answers; lifted mechanical solidarity shares the rules that generate, select, apply, and revise concrete answers. Plural lives and bounded subordinate jurisdictions can follow from that architecture, but do not define it. Whether either form of full capture is open and corrigible or closed and pathological is a separate question.

The bigOther also has a special capacity: it can couple with the bigOthers of other people. It encodes its classifications in words, stories, gestures, roles, titles, symbols, and sanctions that are intelligible within a shared symbolic order. Reciprocal signalling can synchronize many locally programmed individuals into an emergent social field and, under sufficiently integrated conditions, a distributed **multi-mind-self**. Culture is the relatively stable evaluative programming and social coordination produced and reproduced through this loop.

A multi-mind-self need not erase the persons through whom it acts. Culture mechanics therefore distinguishes **differentiated unity**, in which a real *we* preserves different functions, judgments, relationships, and legitimate jurisdictions, from **subjecthood absorption (fusion)**, in which those personal standings are increasingly denied against the collective. Collective agency, synchronization, and fusion are related but independent properties.

Some ideological symbols are **conformity signals**: their performance, absence, or refusal makes a person's relation to the installed program publicly legible. Such signals can turn private classification into monitoring, apparent consensus, recruitment, moralized exclusion, institutional coercion, or collective action. A conformity signal can also become a **targeting signal** when nonperformance exposes a sanctionable outsider; imposed marks and attributed labels can make the same target classification legible without requiring refusal.

In one sentence:

Culture mechanics is the study of how mythologies shape the mythological lens, how the bigOther uses that lens to give social feeling to observations and thoughts, and how networked bigOthers turn those feelings into collective order and action.

Long definition

1. General meaning

Culture mechanics is an explanatory model of culture as a **distributed system of sentiment classification, social coordination, and symbolic reality-construction**.

The term *mechanics* expresses a specific ambition. Culture mechanics does not stop at naming or classifying phenomena such as conformity, indoctrination, collective effervescence, moral commitment, ideology, group identity, or crowd behaviour. It asks how these phenomena are produced:

- What are the functional components?
- What information or programming does each component contain?
- How is that programming learned?
- Which signals activate it?
- How does it influence thought and action?
- How are separate people coordinated or synchronized?
- How is the resulting culture stabilized by rituals and institutions?
- Under what conditions can it be inspected, resisted, or reprogrammed?

Culture mechanics therefore treats culture not merely as a collection of customs or beliefs, but as an operative system with inputs, internal state, evaluative rules, affective outputs, communication channels, feedback loops, and institutional memory. This entry begins with the individual source and coupling interface. The emergent field and its back-action upon epistemic judgment are developed in [Epistemic Agency under Mechanical Solidarity](#).

2. Homo duplex: the dual-processing human

The model calls the human being **homo duplex** because human conduct results from the interaction of two functionally different processing units.

This is a deliberate extension of Émile Durkheim's term rather than a claim that Durkheim described precisely this architecture. In culture mechanics, the duality is between:

1. a powerful general-purpose processor; and

2. a simpler, culturally programmable sentiment-classification processor.

The two units are connected but not reducible to one another within this theory. This is a constitutive functional commitment, not a claim that two anatomical organs have been discovered. The bigOther must therefore not be silently redescribed as merely System 1, a generic heuristic, the superego, internalized norms, or an output of ordinary cognition. Those concepts may illuminate aspects of its operation, but none replaces the proposed second component without revising the theory itself.

A person's intelligence, knowledge, or technical competence does not by itself reveal how the person's bigOther is programmed. The main CPU may remain intelligent, computationally powerful, and capable of elementary verification while the bigOther changes which conclusions feel admissible, honourable, shameful, safe, or unthinkable. Conversely, a person's cultural programming does not determine the full extent of the person's intellectual capacities.

This relative independence explains why a highly intelligent person may be strongly governed by ideological or religious classifications, while a person of ordinary intelligence may preserve considerable moral and epistemic independence. The main processor determines much of what a person *can* think; the bigOther strongly influences which thoughts feel admirable, shameful, safe, dangerous, permissible, or unthinkable.

3. First processing unit: the main CPU

The **main CPU** is the brain's powerful, flexible, general-purpose processing capacity. Its functions include:

- perception and memory;
- language and explicit thought;
- comparison and inference;
- imagination and counterfactual reasoning;
- planning and problem-solving;
- conscious deliberation;
- personal judgment;
- construction of explanations.

Most ordinary conceptions of intelligence focus on this processor. It can learn complex theories, solve technical problems, interpret evidence, and devise sophisticated strategies.

The main CPU does not, however, choose its direction in a cultural vacuum. Attention, motivation, felt relevance, moral urgency, and the acceptability of possible conclusions are influenced by the second processor.

4. Second processing unit: the bigOther

The **bigOther** is the comparatively primitive but strategically placed sentiment-classification processor. Culture mechanics distinguishes its functional operation, its phenomenological appearance, and the shared symbolic interface through which it couples with other local bigOthers.

Functional aspect The local bigOther executes the installed mythological lens. It does not usually produce a detailed argument. It assigns social and moral valence to observations, thoughts, persons, sources, roles, actions, symbols, and events:

observation, thought, person, source, role, action, symbol, or event

↓

MYTHOLOGICAL LENS

learned value-and-feeling mappings

↓

BIGOTHER

fast sentiment classification

↓

honour / shame

loyalty / betrayal

sacred / profane

clean / polluted

legitimate / illicit

safe / threatening

admirable / contemptible

belonging / exclusion

This mapping function corresponds to what **Systems Leadership** calls the **mythological lens**. Culture mechanics treats the lens as the installed evaluative program and the local bigOther as the comparatively simple processor that executes it. Its output can take the form of pride, guilt, shame, disgust, trust, fear, admiration, moral elevation,

indignation, belonging, or anticipated exclusion. These outputs alter which thoughts receive attention, which possibilities are emotionally tolerable, and which actions feel obligatory.

Phenomenological aspect The source of a classification need not be experienced as “my learned social programming.” It may be encountered as an actually present Other—God, Destiny, Nation, History, the People, or the Cause—that sees, judges, addresses, commands, and can receive loyalty, service, protection, or sacrifice. Culture mechanics calls the felt objectivity of this encounter **bigOther-presence** and its second-person relational form **bigOther-as-Thou**.

When the installed program is jealous, this presence may itself be felt directly as jealous: as a *Thou* that claims the person, watches for disloyalty, refuses divided allegiance, and demands fidelity against rivals. The person need not experience this as “my program classified an alternative attachment as betrayal.” It can be lived as “the Other is jealous and requires my loyalty.”

William James’s *The Varieties of Religious Experience* (1902) supplies an important phenomenological antecedent: persons can experience an unseen order or objective presence as more authoritative and conduct-directing than an explicit proposition. Martin Buber’s *I and Thou* (1923) supplies the relational grammar of encountering another as a *Thou* rather than an object or *It*. Neither thinker proposed the culture-mechanical processor or its distributed field. Buber’s eternal *Thou* in particular must not be reduced to a socially programmed classifier. The present terms borrow aspects of their phenomenology while assigning them a different functional explanation.

This account also leaves the metaphysical status of a reported presence open. Its claim is narrower: whatever else the presence may be, the person’s local bigOther can mediate how it becomes socially classified and conduct-directing.

When the mythology represents an agent, several depths of relation and enactment must be distinguished:

Depth	Culture-mechanical description	Relation to fusion
Representation	“This culture tells stories about God, a god, the Nation, History, the People, or the Cause.”	No fusion follows from representation.
Consultation or service	The person asks what the represented agent would judge or accepts obligations toward it.	Personal authorship can remain fully legitimate.
bigOther-as-Thou	The agent is experienced as present, addressing, watching, judging, or commanding the person.	An <i>I–Thou</i> relation still contains two poles; presence is not fusion by itself.
Distributed enactment	Several persons and institutions provide perception, memory, judgment, voice, resources, and action to the represented agent.	Enactment can remain differentiated or become absorptive.
Fused enactment	The collectively enacted agent becomes the authoritative subject and the person’s independent authorship loses standing against it.	This is subjecthood absorption by definition.

The sequence is analytical rather than a necessary developmental ladder. A person can serve without reporting a presence, report a presence without joining a collective agent, or participate in collective enactment while retaining a legitimate conscience, judgment, and right of refusal. Conversely, an intensely agentified programme can make “the Other speaks and acts through me” the operative locus of authorship.

The phrase **agent-model** in this comparison means the culturally specified representation by which people anticipate what an agent perceives, remembers, wants, judges, and commands. It is part of the operative mythological lens; it is not another local bigOther. Nor does analysis of a humanly implemented God-model decide whether God exists independently of that implementation. Culture Mechanics can examine the representation, experience, and social enactment while leaving the theological or metaphysical referent open.

Shared symbolic protocol The spelling **bigOther** marks a deliberate adaptation of Jacques Lacan’s *big Other*, the locus of language, law, roles, conventions, authority, and socially intelligible meaning. Culture mechanics does not identify Lacan’s symbolic order with a processor inside the individual. It treats that shared order, in one functional translation, as the **on-the-wire protocol** through which local bigOthers become mutually legible:

state of A's local bigOther
 ↓ encoded as
 words, stories, gestures, roles, titles, symbols, sanctions
 ↓ transmitted through
 shared symbolic order / Lacanian big Other
 ↓ interpreted through
 B's installed mythological lens
 ↓
 B's sentiment classification and outward response

An alphabet is not a message, and Unicode or ASCII is not the state of the computer using it. They provide shared encodings through which different machines can exchange intelligible signals. Likewise, a letter such as M can denote a complete mathematical mapping, while E or B can denote an entire field. Flags, uniforms, titles, and words such as *betrayal* or *justice* can function as similarly compressed social tokens because participants have learned how to unpack them.

The protocol transmits public signals, not perfect copies of private states. Synchronization requires sufficiently compatible lenses and contexts; it does not require identical inner contents. A signal can therefore activate convergence, misunderstanding, indifference, or opposition.

The bigOther's power comes less from computational sophistication than from its **position in the control architecture**. It influences how a person feels about the main CPU's thoughts. The main CPU may subsequently use its much greater power to explain, implement, defend, or occasionally question the direction supplied by the bigOther.

Historical cause, live classification, and avowed reason A present cultural response can contain three causally distinct layers:

1. **Historical cause:** the remote social experience, institutional arrangement, selection process, conflict, or practical problem through which a rule and its affective weight arose.
2. **Live classification:** the attraction, horror, shame, sacredness, loyalty, or other sentiment currently executed when the operative lens encounters the object.
3. **Avowed reason:** the explanation a person or institution can presently state for that response.

These layers can coincide, but they need not. The original problem can disappear while an affectively alive prohibition remains; a later theology, science, or political doctrine can then supply a new explanation. Conversely, a person can repeat an inherited reason after its corresponding classification has become affectively dead.

Émile Durkheim supplies a particularly clear observation in "[Les principes de 1789 et la sociologie](#)" (1890; Mark Traugott's English translation appears in *Émile Durkheim on Morality and Society*, pp. 34–42). He writes that conscious prescriptions can be "the conscious outcome of an entire unconscious process" and that, without access to their remote causes, "we invent reasons for them, lacking the real ones which we do not see." His kin-marriage example separates a surviving horror from the religious or physiological explanations later offered for it.

This is testimony to the **phenomenon to be explained**, not proof of the present processor architecture. Implicit learning, habit, affective conditioning, predictive processing, strategic rationalization, and other unitary-mind accounts remain alternatives. A discriminating study should therefore vary or measure the three layers separately: alter an explicit reason while holding the social approval environment roughly constant; alter approval while holding the proposition constant; test whether affective reversal precedes or follows doctrinal revision; and compare people who avow the same reason but display different classifications.

5. The single-slot principle

Culture mechanics proposes that the bigOther occupies the equivalent of a computer's **single PCI slot**. There is one slot, one installed local bigOther, and one operative mythological lens at a time. The bigOther is the processor or card; the mythological lens is the executable evaluative program it runs.

A stable program produces **complete slot occupancy**. This document also calls that architectural condition **full capture**. Here *full* means that one operative weave governs the slot, not that the weave is false, totalitarian, or uncorrectable. A **first-order full capture** shares binding concrete rules and answers. A **lifted full capture** shares binding rules that generate, select, apply, and revise concrete answers:

fixed meta-rules M + current knowledge or inputs K_t + situation C → binding first-order output R_t(C)

Here *fixed* means installed and binding at a given time, not eternal. Generator and outputs belong to the same operative weave. Both architectures occupy the slot completely; lifting changes the order at which binding sameness is located rather than producing an empty or half-programmed slot.

Four axes must therefore remain distinct: **slot occupancy** (full), **order level** (shared outputs or shared generator), **jurisdiction** (what the installed rules govern), and **corrigibility** (open or closed). A lifted meta-order can have universal jurisdiction at its own level over the creation, allocation, limitation, coordination, succession, and correction of first-order outputs and jurisdictions. Persons, offices, professions, institutions, communities, and contracting parties may remain plural and domain-limited beneath it. That pluralism is an important possible result of lifting, not its definition.

This **single-slot exclusivity** does not imply that the installed program is simple, culturally pure, or derived from only one source. A person may belong to several groups and encounter many religions, professions, political doctrines, familial obligations, and moral traditions. Compatible material can be assembled like software packages or libraries and braided into one operative lens. The slot restricts the number of independently operative evaluators, not the complexity or modularity of the installed weave.

Compatible packages are not separate bigOthers waiting for a higher process to rank them at runtime. Their objects, authorities, roles, and permissions already receive meaning through the one combined weave. **Paul's pride in supporting himself through work illustrates the point: Christianity and a work ethic need not compete for supremacy.** In [1 Corinthians 9:6–18](#), especially verses 15–18, Paul connects his boast with preaching without making use of his right to material support; [1 Thessalonians 2:9](#) and [2 Thessalonians 3:7–10](#) present labouring so as not to burden the community as an exemplary practice. A Christian mythology package and a *Berufsethos* can therefore reinforce one another within a single program. This is an illustration of compatibility, not population-level proof that every religious and professional package is compatible.

New cultural material consequently has three broad fates:

1. **Incumbent assimilation or rejection:** the installed lens interprets, neutralizes, reuses, or refuses the material in its own terms without surrendering its load-bearing classifications.
2. **Compatible integration:** a package whose important classifications and authority relations can coexist with the incumbent is braided into the one operative lens.
3. **Replacement under incompatibility:** a rival governing program cannot be installed beside the incumbent. The incumbent weave must be loosened and unbraided sufficiently for retained strands and new material to be rebraided into one successor lens.

Within the originating application developed here, **Christianity and the National Socialist worldview are deeply incompatible programming systems** at load-bearing classifications such as God and ultimate authority, the person and neighbour, race and nation, truth, obedience, sacrifice, violence, and loyalty. Nazi programming could not simply be installed beside an intact Christian program. Capture required a replacement process. A Nazi-governed successor could retain Christian words, scripture, symbols, rituals, offices, or a subjective Christian identity, but those strands would receive their operative meaning from the successor weave. The result would be one rebraided Nazi-Christian program, not two programs ordered by rank.

Deep cultural change is therefore unlike adding neutral information to memory. Reprogramming changes the weave that determines what new information means and how it feels. Incomplete replacement can produce contradiction, instability, or a tangled lens during loosening and rebraiding; it does not establish several independent bigOthers running in parallel. This helps explain why conversion, deradicalization, psychoanalysis, moral injury, ideological rupture, and profound changes of identity can be slow, conflictual, and emotionally painful.

Hard cases and possible defeat conditions Single-slot exclusivity cannot be protected merely by redescribing every apparent counterexample as “one complicated braid.” Self-description, retained vocabulary, public ritual, or several group memberships do not decide the architecture. The diagnostic question is:

When inherited authorities conflict over the same act, which rule or authority has final interpretive priority over what the retained material means?

The following observations remain consistent with one slot:

- one tradition interprets the other's retained symbols and practices;
- outward conformity is strategic camouflage under legal or social coercion;
- selected strands have been integrated into one syncretic successor;
- a third rule governs how both inheritances are combined;

- or the person is in unstable, incomplete unbraiding and rebraiding.

A strong candidate counterexample requires substantially more:

1. two governing evaluators issue incompatible classifications in the same domain;
2. each remains independently final rather than being interpreted, authorized, or limited by the other or by a third rule;
3. each can generate its own affect, guilt, correction, and veto;
4. neither is merely reflective knowledge, role performance, strategic concealment, or a de-animated remnant; and
5. the configuration remains stable over time rather than resolving into hierarchy, integration, replacement, or breakdown.

Evidence of that pattern would count against strict single-slot exclusivity. The theory would then need either a principled account of parallel operative evaluators or revision of the one-slot commitment. Evidence for only labels, rituals, memories, or alternating contexts is insufficient because one weave can assign different outputs to different contexts. The detailed dual-religious- identification boundary case belongs to [Epistemic Agency under Mechanical Solidarity](#), “Examples, cases, and boundary tests”.

6. Systems Leadership: mythologies and the mythological lens

Systems Leadership: Creating Positive Organisations, by Ian Macdonald, Catherine Burke, and Karl Stewart, supplies the definitive practical account used by Culture Mechanics for how culture is deliberately implemented. Its method coordinates leadership behaviour, systems, symbols, mythologies, habits, organizational arrangements, and repeated experience rather than treating mythology as sufficient by itself. Culture Mechanics embeds that organizational and workplace account in a larger theory and develops selected extensions and refinements; readers seeking the exact implementation method should read the book.

Culture mechanics adopts the following terminological hierarchy:

Term	Definition in culture mechanics
Mythology	One socially evaluated story or narrative unit. It need not involve gods or supernatural events. It shows persons, roles, actions, conflicts, and consequences while indicating what deserves admiration, shame, loyalty, fear, trust, disgust, or condemnation.
Mythologies	The accumulated and partly interconnected body of such stories available to a person or group. They provide many examples of how the social world is supposed to be interpreted.
Mythological lens	The generalized mapping formed from those mythologies and reinforced by systems, symbols, rituals, sanctions, and observed conduct. It maps real-world observations and events onto culturally learned values and feelings.
bigOther	The local sentiment-classification processor that executes the installed mythological lens and applies its mappings quickly.

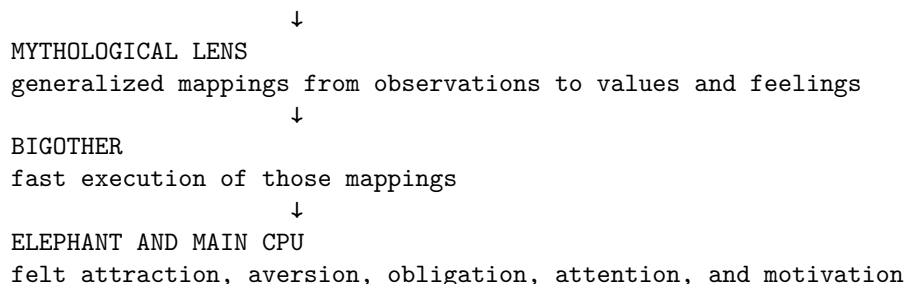
The lens is one executable weave but may be modular. Mythologies, practices, professional ethics, familial duties, and local customs can operate as mutually compatible packages within it. Their plurality is a plurality of constituent strands and context-sensitive mappings, not a plurality of local bigOthers.

This yields the central culture-mechanical sequence:

```

MYTHOLOGY
one evaluated story
      ↓
MYTHOLOGIES
many mutually reinforcing stories

```

An individual mythology can teach:

- which kinds of persons and roles exist;
- what counts as a good group member;
- which authorities are legitimate;
- which conduct receives praise or condemnation;
- which sacrifices are honourable;
- what constitutes betrayal, pollution, injustice, or redemption;
- how the past explains the present;
- what the group expects of the individual;
- which future is desirable or disastrous.

A story acts as an evaluated simulation. Narrative transportation places the listener inside a conflict; a hero or villain demonstrates a possible response; consequences display what follows; praise or condemnation supplies the sentiment label; and the audience's reaction shows whether the classification is collectively shared. Each story is one training example. Many convergent stories allow the bigOther to generalize a lens that can classify new situations never described in any one story.

Relevant structures and moral appraisal Dushan Wegner's *Relevante Strukturen* (2019; ISBN 9783739405636) calls attention to the relations in which a person is embedded and to the larger structures that the person experiences as important. Culture Mechanics adopts **relevant structure** as a typed relational object rather than as a synonym for anything a person happens to value:

A **relevant structure** is a represented relational arrangement or organized condition—such as a family, friendship, profession, institution, community, legal order, practice, person-in-relation, or anticipated shared future—that the installed mythological lens treats as carrying moral weight.

Not every desired object, isolated preference, or momentarily salient stimulus is therefore a relevant structure. The term emphasizes embedding, dependence, continuity, function, and vulnerability. A mythology can teach which structures exist, who or what belongs within them, how they depend upon one another, what counts as supporting or damaging them, whose claims have precedence when they conflict, and who has standing or jurisdiction to judge and act.

Wegner's memorable formulation that good strengthens relevant structures and evil weakens them is incorporated as the **relevant-structure appraisal hypothesis**:

People often experience an action, omission, continuation, or proposed change as good when they believe it strengthens, protects, repairs, or honourably serves a structure they experience as relevant, and as evil when they believe it weakens, corrupts, betrays, or destroys such a structure.

This is a descriptive hypothesis about moral perception and mobilization, not a sufficient definition of moral truth and not a claim that every moral judgment uses this route. The analysis must keep five variables distinct:

Variable	Question
Felt relevance	How much moral weight does this person or operative culture assign to the represented structure?
Represented effect	What does the person believe the action will do to it?
Actual effect	What does the action do, including indirect, delayed, and transferred effects?
Generative centrality	How strongly does the structure actually produce capabilities or conditions upon which several downstream structures depend?

Variable	Question
Normative standing	Is the structure, claimed effect, jurisdiction, or proposed sacrifice legitimate?

Generative centrality—also described more informally as *load-bearingness*—is therefore not another name for felt relevance. A structure may be causally central to the production of character, knowledge, cooperation, or institutional continuity while receiving little explicit moral attention. Conversely, an intensely felt-relevant structure may be weakly generative, replaceable, or destructive. A **cultural sublimation architecture** is a particularly important proposed case: it can recurrently produce capacities upon which families, professions, law, science, markets, and political institutions depend even when the operative culture does not represent that architecture itself as relevant. The concept and its limits are developed in *Mythology Construction*, “Sublimation and moral formation.”

The mismatch is analytically consequential:

high generative centrality
+ low felt relevance
→ weak protection and transmission
→ vulnerability to neglect, ridicule, dismantling,
or consumption of inherited cultural capital

This is a hypothesis about dependency and reproduction, not a presumption that every inherited arrangement is beneficial or that whatever calls itself civilizational must be preserved.

Wegner’s emphasis on *Veränderung* also motivates the more limited **change-indexed moral-mobilization hypothesis**:

Moral classification often becomes especially salient and action-directing when a condition is represented as causing, accelerating, continuing, preventing, or culpably failing to prevent a change in a felt-relevant structure.

This concerns represented counterfactual movement, not physical novelty. “The rule exists” can be rendered as “officials continue the rule,” “participants decline to end it,” or “the institution prevents transition to an alternative.” Conversely, the absence of visible mobilization does not establish that the status quo is experienced as good: coercion, habituation, helplessness, low salience, concealed dissent, and the absence of a represented alternative are competing explanations. A direct test would hold material conditions constant while comparing a static-state description, an active-continuation description, and a prevented-alternative description. Failure of these descriptions to alter moral intensity or action readiness, especially across independently measured relevance, would weaken the hypothesis.

The mythological lens need not calculate complex consequences by itself. Ordinary cognition, testimony, institutions, and a mythology’s causal stories can supply a represented effect model; the local bigOther then rapidly classifies the represented support or damage through the installed lens:

observed, proposed, continued, or prevented change
↓
main CPU + received causal stories represent likely effects
↓
operative lens supplies felt relevance, moral meaning,
precedence, standing, and jurisdiction
↓
local bigOther classifies protection/injury, loyalty/betrayal,
repair/destruction, justice/injustice, honour/shame
↓
attention, judgment, motivation, and action are redirected

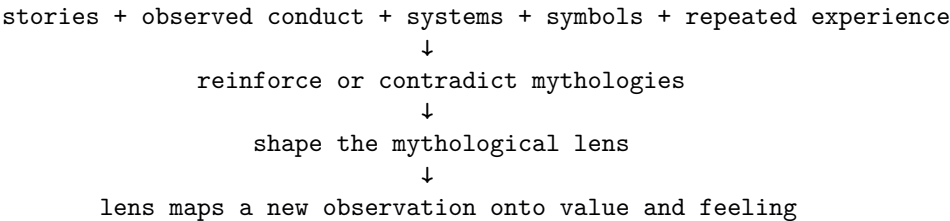
“Strengthening” and “weakening” are multidimensional rather than one moral scalar. An oppressive institution may increase its continuity, capacity, reach, or internal cohesion while destroying truth-contact, corrigibility, personal standing, or legitimate exit and while transferring severe costs to other persons and structures. The appraisal hypothesis explains why participants may nevertheless experience its preservation as good; it does not vindicate that appraisal.

Several relevant structures can coexist within the one operative weave without implying several local bigOthers. Their relative weight, conflict rules, and jurisdictions are program content. A predominantly first-order solidarity

may make a concrete hierarchy of structures binding as such. A lifted solidarity may make binding a procedure by which competing claims are evidenced, limited, adjudicated, appealed, and revised. This is an application of the order-level distinction, not its definition; in both cases the one slot remains fully occupied.

Systems Leadership adds an important qualification: explicit stories are not the only influences on the lens. The conduct of leaders, the design of systems, the use of symbols, institutional rewards and sanctions, and repeated experiences of belonging, success, humiliation, or exclusion can confirm or contradict the lessons conveyed by a mythology. These experiences may themselves later be narrated as new mythologies.

The relationship is therefore not simply “a story causes a feeling.” Rather:



Systems Leadership commonly describes the lens as evaluating behaviour, systems, and symbols along continua such as:

- honesty–dishonesty;
- trust–distrust;
- courage–cowardice;
- respect–disrespect for human dignity;
- fairness–unfairness;
- love or care–indifference.

Culture mechanics interprets these as important output dimensions of the programmed bigOther. They are not necessarily an exhaustive list of human moral sentiments, but they show concretely what the lens does: it converts a physical or social observation into an affectively consequential classification.

When people possess sufficiently similar mythological lenses, they tend to interpret the same conduct in similar ways. Systems Leadership calls the resulting shared evaluative pattern culture. Culture mechanics adds that compatible local bigOthers can also exchange signals and synchronize, turning shared classification into distributed affect and coordinated action.

7. Programming, activation, and reprogramming

Culture mechanics distinguishes several operations that are easily confused:

Operation	Timescale	Function
Programming	Slow	Adds, reinforces, or revises mythologies and compatible packages and thereby installs, extends, or modifies the one mythological lens used by the bigOther.
Classification	Very fast	The bigOther applies the installed lens to a person, thought, action, symbol, or event.
Activation	Fast	A present signal activates an already learned mapping in the lens.
Synchronization	Fast	Reciprocal signals align the affective or behavioural states of several people.

Operation	Timescale	Function
Reinforcement	Repeated	Successful, praised, punished, or emotionally intense execution stabilizes mythologies and their mappings in the lens.
Reprogramming	Usually slow	Modifies the operative weave. Compatible change can extend or repair it; incompatible replacement requires sufficient unbraiding of the incumbent and rebraiding of one successor lens.
Unbraiding and rebraiding	Usually slow and conflictual	Loosens load-bearing bindings, preserves or detaches selected strands, crosses a potentially unstable interval, and installs one successor weave rather than a parallel evaluator.

Applied to relevant structures, **relevance activation** foregrounds a concern and appraisal mapping already installed in the lens. **Relevance reprogramming** changes which relational arrangements carry moral weight, how strongly they matter, what support or damage means, or how conflicts among them are resolved. Repeated foregrounding may reinforce and eventually help reprogram the lens, but a one-shot increase in salience does not by itself establish durable reprogramming.

The theory studies one endogenous formation path and one prospective purposive research route.

Endogenous mythology formation is the largely distributed and not centrally designed process through which changes in social structure, institutions, lived practice, and receiver dispositions generate pressures, needs, and aspirations; competing articulations are then selected, sacralized, embodied, and reproduced. It is the ordinary cultural-growth path. *Endogenous* describes causal provenance, not innocence, health, inevitability, or moral legitimacy.

Purposive mythology construction is the open research possibility that a person, office, organization, or coalition might adopt a proposed destination and deliberately intervene in the mythologies, causal classifications, symbols, roles, permissions, and supporting institutions through which a population interprets and acts. Any attempted constructor remains inside culture: the desired destination, available materials, authority, and perception of the problem have themselves been culturally formed, and the intervention becomes one more input into receiver, institutional, rival, and reality selection.

The detailed semantic definition, design audit, and workflow belong to [Mythology Construction](#); the present section states only the distinction needed by the core causal cycle.

ENDOGENOUS FORMATION

changing conditions → diffuse mismatch → competing articulations
→ distributed selection → embodiment and reproduction

PROSPECTIVE PURPOSIVE CONSTRUCTION

chosen destination D*
→ diagnose receivers, incumbent order, and likely baseline trajectory
→ deliberately alter mythologies and supporting arrangements
→ prototype, observe, correct, defend, or retire

The prospective branch treats mythology as a privileged symbolic intervention surface because evaluated stories encode roles, causes, values, permissions, and consequences in a form close to the bigOther's learned operations. It is not the whole implementation surface. Leadership behaviour, systems, symbols, habits, rewards, sanctions, material conditions, and repeated experience may confirm, redirect, or defeat an intended mythology. An attempted purpose therefore does not imply control:

actual successor
= intended destination × receiver fit × incumbent resistance

Culture-mechanical object	Meaning	Examples
Program complex	A large, internally structured package capable of programming an operative mythological lens	Religions, Marxism, National Socialism, liberal constitutional culture, nationalism, company cultures, activist movements, military ethos, professional cultures, state programmes
Program unit or content	Material from which a larger operative weave is constructed	Mythologies, narratives, causal stories, moral rules, roles, exemplars, sacred values, master signifiers
Carrier or activation device	A token through which the program is communicated, activated, or made publicly legible	Flags, veils, blue neckerchiefs, imposed yellow stars, badges, certificates, slogans, linguistic forms, masks, salutes, songs, whistle signals
Implementation arrangement	A durable structure that rewards, sanctions, repeats, or institutionalizes the program	Schools, appointment systems, rituals, calendars, dress codes, promotion criteria, laws, media routines, organizational systems
Local execution	The installed program as executed by an individual sentiment classifier	A local bigOther applying its mythological lens
Collective formation	The emergent result of compatible local execution and reciprocal signalling	Mechanical solidarity and the distributed bigOther
Collective agent	A sufficiently integrated and continuous collective formation capable of judgment, intention, ownership, and action	A multi-mind-self

A culturally legible phrase, song, image, hero, or ritual that evokes a shared sublimation remains a **carrier or activation device**, an **ideological symbol**, a master-signifier-like token, or a fragment of mythology according to its actual function. The Wegner-facing expression **sublimation emblem** may be useful as explanatory shorthand for its compressed representative role, but it does not create a new culture-mechanical object type. Analysis must keep separate the sublimation process, its resulting character or practice, the cultural sublimation architecture that recurrently produces it, and the token that activates relevant programming.

In common contemporary political, organizational, and media usage, **narrative** is often a fuzzy synonym for **mythology**. Culture mechanics retains a precise boundary inside that overlap. *Narrative* is the broader term for an organized account of events, actors, causes, and consequences. A narrative becomes culture-mechanically mythological when it also carries socially learned evaluation, roles, causal interpretation, expected feeling, or permission—when it teaches not only what happened but what should feel admirable, shameful, legitimate, treacherous, threatening, redemptive, permitted, or forbidden. A merely chronological account need not be a mythology. A **causal story** is a narrative specialized around explaining why something happened and assigning agency or responsibility. The common political expression “**the narrative**” may refer more broadly to an authorized mythology, mythology family, or even the lens through which events are required to be interpreted; its precise level must be identified from context.

At the applied level, **narrative design** and **narrative construction** are therefore close practitioner-language synonyms for **mythology construction**. *Mythology Construction* develops this relationship and identifies existing narrative-design toolkits as partial practical implementations of the same intervention domain.

A whole religion, political formation, company culture, activist movement, or state programme may be a **composite culture-mechanical object** containing several of these subtypes. The name *Christianity*, *Islam*, *Judaism*, *Marxism*, *National Socialism*, or *company culture* may refer in one sentence to a body of programming and in another to its institutions, carriers, synchronized population, or collective agency. Analysis must therefore identify which level is meant rather than treating the inherited name as a precise ontology.

What the theory is disentangling Ordinary vocabulary often uses *religion*, *ideology*, *culture*, *collective consciousness*, *big Other*, or *group mind* as near-synonyms. Culture mechanics treats religion and secular ideology as members of the same broad family of cultural programming while refusing to collapse program, processor, protocol, field, and agent:

Construct	Precise role in culture mechanics
Cultural or ideological program	The executable package of mythologies, classifications, rules, roles, values, and expected conduct installed as one operative weave.
Mythological lens	The generalized mapping through which observations are converted into culturally learned values and feelings.
Ideological symbol	A socially legible token that activates the program and communicates a person's relation to it.
Conformity signal	An ideological symbol whose performance or nonperformance makes conformity and deviation publicly legible.
Targeting signal	A performed, omitted, imposed, or attributed token that assigns a person or population to a sanctionable out-group.
Local bigOther	The individual sentiment classifier that executes the installed lens.
Lacan's big Other	The shared symbolic vocabulary and protocol through which the program and its tokens become publicly intelligible.
Mechanical solidarity	The synchronized symbolic-affective coherence produced through compatible local execution and reciprocal response.
Distributed bigOther	The persistent network state maintained through persons, institutions, practices, artifacts, reputations, and sanctions.
Multi-mind-self	The distributed system only when it becomes sufficiently integrated and continuous to judge, intend, own, and act as a collective agent.

In this section, **ideological** is the broad, religion-inclusive adjective for anything pertaining to such a cultural program. It includes religious, political, organizational, professional, activist, national, and lifestyle programs. This broad use must be distinguished from the narrower **ideological form**, the third member of the private-collective-ideological-fundamentalist taxonomy below. The expression **ideological-form program** names that third configuration when the two senses might otherwise be confused.

Disagreement, mythological rivalry, and ideological-form conflict The broad adjective *ideological* must not turn every disagreement into one undifferentiated "ideological conflict." Culture mechanics distinguishes the object and intensity of conflict:

Term	Culture-mechanical meaning
Propositional disagreement	Incompatible truth claims that need not involve rival governing lenses.
Causal-story conflict	Incompatible accounts of agents, causes, intentions, responsibility, or remedy.
Classification conflict	Incompatible assignments of identity, status, purity, legitimacy, or permission.
Mythological rivalry	Informal or decentralized competition among meaning systems, including lifestyles, religions, political outlooks, and institutional cultures.

Term	Culture-mechanical meaning
Mythological conflict	Active interference with a rival mythology's transmission, authority, membership, or institutional embodiment.
Cultural-program conflict	Competition between incompatible governing programs or operative lenses, especially where single-slot replacement is at stake.
Ideological-form conflict	Organized recruitment, formation, conformity testing, delegitimation, and interference with a rival program's reproduction.
Fundamentalist-form conflict	Ideological-form conflict in which expansion, retention, punishment, expulsion, or elimination authorizes or uses physical coercion or violence.

Rivalry becomes conflict when participants begin actively interfering with the rival mythology's transmission, authority, membership, or institutional embodiment.

Mythological rivalry can therefore persist without organized conflict. The transition can occur through recruitment campaigns, polemical unbraiding, conformity tests, delegitimation, exclusion from channels, institutional displacement, or censorship. *Mythology Construction*, "Mythological replacement: braiding, apologetics, and polemics," develops these operations and the problem of installing a successor weave.

Kenneth Minogue calls the organized struggle **ideological conflict**. In the preface to the second edition, dated January 2006 (p. xvi), of *Alien Powers: The Pure Theory of Ideology*, he argues that an initial move is to disable opposition, ideally by censorship. In Culture Mechanics terminology, this maps most directly to **ideological-form conflict**, and to **fundamentalist-form conflict** when physical coercion or violence becomes the means of expansion or retention. Minogue's narrower, mobilizing, conflict-centered conception must not be silently equated with the broad religion-inclusive adjective *ideological* used in this document.

Call censorship or channel exclusion **rival-signal suppression** when it obstructs a competing mythology's signals, and **counter-program suppression** when it attacks the rival program's reproduction or institutional embodiment. A counter-narrative is not analytically random noise: it may carry a rival mythology, independent evidence, an internal correction, minority perception, or innovation. For the relationship between this distinction and the physical noise-suppression heuristic, see *Analogical Models in Culture Mechanics: A Semantic Inventory*, "Positive feedback, noise, and rival signals." These conflict terms are project-developed translations; they are not Minogue's taxonomy.

Ideological symbols must be classified by function

An ideological symbol is a material object, word, linguistic form, gesture, sound, image, ritual, omission, or other socially legible token that activates an installed ideological program and communicates a person's relation to that program.

The medium is incidental to the definition. A piece of cloth, grammatical ending, salute, profile image, whistle pattern, silence, refusal to applaud, or continued association with an excluded person can perform the same operation when participants know how to decode it. A symbol can be simultaneously functional in another domain: a mask can be a medical device and also acquire a moral-political meaning; clothing can protect from weather and also display membership. The presence of one function neither proves nor excludes the other.

Ideological symbols can perform several distinguishable functions:

1. activate an installed program;
2. cue the carrier's conduct;
3. display affiliation or membership;
4. distinguish insiders from outsiders;
5. advertise the program or invite imitation;
6. test conformity and expose deviation;
7. assign or expose a sanctionable out-group;
8. synchronize attention, affect, identity, judgment, or action;
9. manufacture apparent consensus;
10. mark refusal as moral or character failure;
11. communicate a claim to wider social jurisdiction;
12. enable social, institutional, legal, or physical sanctions.

No one token necessarily performs every function. Function must be inferred from the surrounding program, expectations, audience, treatment of refusal, and actual institutional consequences rather than from material form, religious or secular origin, or the stated intention of one carrier.

Conformity signals

An ideological symbol becomes a conformity signal when its performance, display, absence, refusal, or substitution makes conformity and deviation publicly legible and thereby enables monitoring, reinforcement, sanction, recruitment, exclusion, or a claim to wider jurisdiction.

A **boundary signal** distinguishes insiders from outsiders. A **propagation signal** is designed or selected for easy public reproduction and advertises, normalizes, or spreads the program. A secret greeting may mainly mark a boundary; a slogan, salute, hashtag, linguistic convention, pledge, or clothing expectation may invite or pressure everyone to repeat it. One symbol can perform both functions.

Targeting signals Conformity signals and target markers are not mutually exclusive material classes. They name functions that may overlap in the same token or expectation:

A targeting signal is any performed, omitted, imposed, or attributed socially legible token that assigns a person or population to a sanctionable out-group and thereby makes exclusion, coercion, persecution, or violence easier to direct.

Here **sanctionable** means treated by the program as available for sanction; it does not mean that the classification or sanction is justified.

A conformity signal becomes a targeting signal when its absence, refusal, substitution, or incorrect performance makes the nonconforming person legible as a sanctionable outsider.

The relevant **signal polarity** is how the classification becomes visible, not whether the carrier voluntarily communicates it:

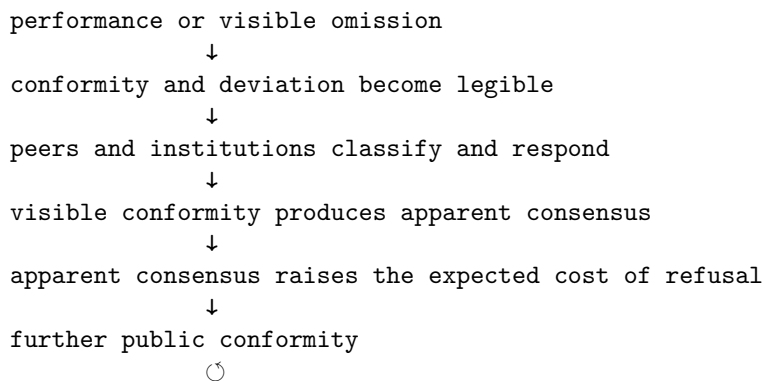
Mode	Culture-mechanical operation	Vivid example
Performed conformity	Display marks the person as one of “us”	Blue neckerchief, expected mask, badge, salute, pledge, or prescribed linguistic form
Negative targeting through nonperformance	Absence, refusal, substitution, or incorrect performance identifies the deviant	Missing neckerchief, unmasked face where masking is expected, absent certificate, refused salute, or unapproved wording
Imposed target marking	A hostile authority forces the out-group classification onto its target	The yellow star imposed on Jews under National Socialism
Attributed target marking	A name, accusation, record, database entry, or administrative category assigns target status without requiring a visible token	“Heretic,” “class enemy,” “extremist,” “unvaccinated,” or a corresponding institutional record when the classification routes sanctions

The blue neckerchief and the yellow star therefore differ in their direction of assignment but can converge downstream. The neckerchief marks the compliant member and its absence can expose a nonconforming target. The yellow star directly and forcibly marks the person whom the governing program classifies as an outsider. Both make a culturally defined boundary operational by making persons sortable.

COVID-19 supplies a particularly clear mixed case. An unmasked face could become a negative targeting signal wherever masking was expected and refusal was treated as evidence of irresponsibility, danger, or defective character. Vaccination status was normally not visible by itself; certificates, database checks, disclosure requirements, denied access, and verbal classification made it legible. The official phrase “**pandemic of the unvaccinated**” turned a biomedical status into a named causal category within public discourse and was explicitly joined to vaccination requirements. In a given setting, whether this classification became a targeting signal must be tested by examining blame, expected displays, access conditions, sanctions, and the treatment of refusal. This functional analysis does

not by itself decide the empirical accuracy, medical value, legality, proportionality, or moral legitimacy of a mask or vaccine policy.

The decisive operation can therefore be negative. Where a display is expected, its absence identifies the person who has not complied without requiring that person to make a declaration. The signal thereby turns conduct into public telemetry:



When the performance is mutually observable, it can also generate **common knowledge**: participants know the signal, know that others received it, and know that others can observe their own response. [Michael Suk-Young Chwe's *Rational Ritual*](#) supplies this coordination mechanism. Common knowledge can organize outward conduct without proving private assent or the complete culture-mechanical account.

This loop can produce sincere convergence, strategic compliance, preference falsification, pluralistic ignorance, or a mixture of them. [Timur Kuran's *Private Truths, Public Lies*](#) supplies the established neighbouring mechanism in which public expression diverges from private preference under pressure. [Václav Havel's *The Power of the Powerless*](#) shows how ritual public conformity can reproduce a system without requiring private belief. Culture mechanics adds the local-processor, symbolic-protocol, and field account; neither author proposed this complete synthesis.

The installed program also supplies a virtual **yardstick of the good member**: a good hunter, vegan, worker, believer, citizen, revolutionary, or comrade. The conformity signal makes a person's apparent position against that yardstick visible. Assenting to an absurd statement can therefore become an especially powerful loyalty test: agreement with "2 + 2 = 5" communicates little about arithmetic but much about willingness to submit. Signals can also mark enemies. Public rejection of a stigmatized word, object, person, or association may become its own proof of belonging.

A compulsory conformity signal is not automatically a **credibility-enhancing display** or CRED. In Joseph Henrich's narrower model, costly conduct by a model can make professed commitment credible; see "[The Evolution of Costly Displays, Cooperation and Religion](#)". With a compulsory symbol, the principal cost may fall on refusal rather than on performance, and compliance may be purely strategic. **Sanction-backed conformity signal, compulsory membership signal, or public loyalty marker** is then more precise. No unvalidated checklist or numerical threshold should be presented as a CRED measure.

Beseelung and four propagation and enforcement forms The originating **dead-alive** analogy distinguishes information that is merely known from programming that animates conduct. A relatively dead rule resembles "stop at the red pedestrian light": a person can notice and ignore it without much guilt. An alive practice can make omission feel like personal failure, guilt, or betrayal. The German **beseelt**—literally, in a poetic translation, "ensouled"—better conveys this experienced animation than the bloodless word *stored*.

Beseelung is an independent axis. It concerns how affectively alive and conduct-directing a program is, not how widely it recruits or how aggressively it enforces. A private dietary or yoga practice can be intensely alive. A football crowd can synchronize powerfully without seeking converts. A perfectly conforming functionary can privately believe nothing, and a fundamentalist system can be enforced by cynical officials.

When a programme contains an agent-model, **agentified Beseelung** can make that agent sufficiently present within local evaluation that the person begins to perceive, judge, and act from its represented perspective. This joins the dead-alive axis to bigOther-presence without making them synonyms: a practice can be deeply *beseelt* without a personified Thou, and an asserted vision or voice does not by itself establish durable affective animation, distributed agency, or fusion.

Relative deadness can also be a historical remainder. A culture may preserve a rule, word, symbol, institution, or habitual procedure after losing the mythology, rituals, practices, and transmission relations that once made it

sacred, identity-bearing, and synchronizing. Such a remnant can remain functionally useful: the pedestrian signal still coordinates movement even when it no longer evokes guilt, sacrifice, or an experience of collective being. A later observer who sees only that remnant cannot safely infer that the rule was always affectively dead.

This creates a three-way calm-period ambiguity: an intact cultural system may be **dormant**; surviving material may be **de-animated**; or the former synchronization technology may be **culturally lost** and require successor construction rather than reactivation. Loss of that technology does not empty the one PCI slot: another operative mythological weave still occupies the local bigOther. [Epistemic Agency under Mechanical Solidarity](#), “[Observability, cultural forgetting, and contemporary witnesses](#)” states the historical hypothesis and evidential problem. [Analogical Models in Culture Mechanics: A Semantic Inventory](#) maps them to the nested quantum, laser, magnetism, weak-field gravity, and contemporary-witness pictures.

The private–collective–ideological–fundamentalist distinction classifies dominant **propagation and enforcement configurations**, not different kinds of bigOther and not a necessary sequence through which every program passes:

Form	Characteristic propagation	Typical symbolic function	Treatment of nonparticipation
Private	Self-selection and personal discovery	Self-cue, personal commitment, optional recognition	Normally irrelevant to outsiders; private relational boundaries may still be strong
Collective	Attraction, affiliation, and display of the pleasures of belonging	Membership, shared enjoyment, ritual synchronization, advertisement of the community	Usually tolerated, although reputation and coordinated ostracism become possible
Ideological form	Active recruitment, education, and formation in the “correct” way of being	Public conformity, loyalty tests, mission, and apparent unanimity	Moral, social, educational, or institutional pressure
Fundamentalist	Militant expansion, retention, or defence	Mobilization, enemy marking, surveillance, and demonstrations of irreversible commitment	Authorization or willingness to use physical coercion or violence to convert, retain, punish, expel, or eliminate

Vivid ideal-type examples:

- In the **private form**, consider a dietary or yoga practice found and adopted on one’s own initiative. Communities of practice may exist, but the program does not strongly recruit outsiders.
- In the **collective form**, consider football-club or pop-star fandom. It attracts through advertising, spectacle, and the visible pleasures of belonging rather than demanding conversion.
- In the **ideological form**, consider a proselytizing religion or a political movement such as Marxism. Mission, education, cadre formation, or comparable training forms members in the “correct” way of being.
- In the **fundamentalist form**, consider a militant religious or political movement willing to use bodily force to convert or retain members, punish refusal, expel opponents, or eliminate rivals.

These examples make the forms concrete; they do not establish that every instance belongs wholly to one form. Whole religions, cultures, institutions, or movements may nevertheless be classified as predominantly one form when the scope, evidence, countercases, and possible falsifiers are stated.

The taxonomy is a project-developed synthesis, not a classification attributed to [Susan Blackmore’s account of memes and temes](#). Her replicator account supplies a neighbouring way to think about copied cultural information; the four forms classify the propagation and enforcement configurations in which a program is reproduced. Their variability illustrates the originating software analogy: programs are flexible—that is the force of *soft* in *software*.

The forms compress several axes that must remain separately inspectable:

- depth of *Beseelung*;
- public visibility;
- outward recruitment or proselytism;

- inward retention and treatment of exit;
- lateral intolerance of rival allegiance;
- jurisdiction over domains of life;
- synchronization strength;
- social and institutional sanctions;
- authorization or willingness to use physical violence.

Strong conviction is not by itself fundamentalism. Proselytism is not jealousy; jealousy is not physical violence; and discursive violence, defined below, can occur before the fundamentalist form.

Jealous programs, solidarity, and collective agents The originating analogy is deliberately vivid:

A jealous multi-mind-self resembles a jealous lover who wants to own the beloved and cannot tolerate divided allegiance.

The corresponding operational definition is:

A jealous cultural program claims exclusive allegiance, classifies incompatible commitment, dissent, or exit as betrayal, and mobilizes symbols, sanctions, institutions, and collective affect to defend that claim.

[Kenneth Minogue's *Alien Powers: The Pure Theory of Ideology*](#) provides a close published neighbour in its treatment of ideological revelation as jealous and expansionary. **Jealous cultural program** and its integration with the present ontology are project-developed terms, not Minogue's complete theory.

Jealousy must be attributed at the correct level:

Level	Operation in a jealous configuration
Lacan's big Other	Carries publicly intelligible categories and tokens such as loyalty, betrayal, idolatry, heresy, oath, flag, scarf, and rival symbol. It is the protocol, not the jealous agent.
Local bigOther	Executes a jealous lens and makes rival allegiance, refusal, or exit feel shameful, contaminating, frightening, or treacherous. In bigOther-presence , and especially bigOther-as-Thou , the person may directly feel a present jealous Other that claims fidelity and refuses divided allegiance. Calling the processor itself jealous remains functional shorthand for the program it executes; calling the experienced presence jealous describes how that operation can be lived.
Mechanical solidarity	Synchronizes compatible classifications and reciprocal enforcement.
Distributed bigOther	Preserves the network state through expectations, reputations, rituals, institutions, symbols, and sanctions.
Multi-mind-self	If the collective-agent threshold is met, the integrated system can itself claim, condemn, exclude, punish, or attack through its members and institutions.

Jealousy therefore has both an **analytical description** and a **phenomenological appearance**. Analytically, the installed program defines exclusive loyalty and the local bigOther executes its classifications. Phenomenologically, a jealous God, Nation, People, History, or Cause may be encountered as personally present—watching, addressing, claiming, accusing, or demanding sacrifice. This direct individual experience does not collapse the local processor into Lacan's shared symbolic protocol, and it does not by itself establish that the surrounding distributed bigOther has crossed the multi-mind-self threshold.

Single-slot exclusivity is not jealousy. Every stable program fully occupies the one local slot, including an open, pluralistic, lifted program. Jealousy begins when the installed program additionally demands exclusive allegiance, treats legitimate rivalry or replacement as betrayal, blocks dignified exit, claims the whole person, exceeds its jurisdiction, or monopolizes authoritative interpretation.

Jealousy and proselytism are hypothesized to reinforce one another often, especially in ideological-form and fundamentalist programs, but they are not identical. A separatist sect can retain members jealously while seeking no converts; a missionary movement can recruit energetically while respecting refusal and exit. Analysis should therefore record outward recruitment, inward retention, rival intolerance, jurisdiction, and enforcement separately.

[Exodus 20:3 and 20:5](#) supply the theological exemplar of a jealous God, exclusive covenant loyalty, and “no other gods.” The jealous-lover comparison uses this as an analogy for the classification of rival attachment as betrayal or idolatry, not as empirical proof of the social mechanism. The related Christian interpretation—that the human capacity to join a multi-mind-self is the “God-shaped hole” that should be filled by God rather than a human ideological collective—is an originating confessional interpretation, not a general scientific proposition or a settled philological claim.

Moralization as character accusation: Andrick’s bridge [Michael Andrick’s *Im Moralegefängnis: Spaltung verstehen und überwinden*](#) supplies the missing micro-mechanism between moral classification, conformity signalling, exclusion, and escalating violence. In Andrick’s account, misplaced moralization performs two changes at once:

1. **Focus:** the exchange moves from the disputed issue to the other person’s character.
2. **Mode:** inquiry and argument become accusation and prosecution.

His kindergarten example preserves the operation vividly. A discussion about whether a kindergarten should have two or three floors becomes a trial of whether one participant is a good person who deserves to remain in the discussion. A fleeting statement or minor act is read as a revealing disclosure of character; the alleged disclosure becomes a character accusation; and the person’s standing, rather than the proposition, becomes the target:

```
factual disagreement or missing conformity signal
↓
statement, omission, or association becomes "character disclosure"
↓
character accusation
↓
inquiry becomes prosecution
↓
discursive standing is attacked
↓
submit, recant, or be excluded
```

Andrick’s strong verdict is that **moralization is discursive violence** and makes physical violence more likely. Its immediate domination does not require bodily force: it attacks the other’s recognized standing and invokes the background threat, “You may not be breaking public law, but you are breaking my law; submit or I will exclude you.” Even legitimate moral condemnation remains aggressive in this account. In private relationships it is the metaphorical **atomic bomb**, or the sharpest social weapon, although consciously removing an intolerable person from one’s voluntary private circle may itself be legitimate.

The tendency toward violence therefore cannot simply be abolished in Andrick’s account: even justified moral condemnation contains an exclusionary threat. His associated freedom claim is equally strong—pathological moralization and free self-determination cannot coexist. Official voluntariness does not settle the question when refusing a prescribed linguistic form, dress expectation, ritual, or declaration brings foreseeable moral, social, or professional punishment.

Culture mechanics extends rather than merely repeats Andrick’s account:

```
local bigOther classifies a person as bad, disloyal, or unbearable
↓ encoded through
shared accusation, stigma, required denunciation, or conformity test
↓ reciprocally reinforced as
mechanical solidarity and collective exclusion
↓ preserved through
distributed reputations, institutional routines, records, and sanctions
↓ possibly executed by
a multi-mind-self capable of organized judgment and action
```

Guilt by association is a secondary conformity signal. Continuing to speak with an excluded person, refusing to denounce them, or preserving a public relationship can itself be treated as a character disclosure. Cancel culture,

refusal to enter discussion with opponents, mandatory denunciation, and the public sorting of people into epistemic tribes are candidate manifestations of this mechanism; each case still requires evidence that the operation actually occurred.

Division is therefore not merely a static condition. It can be continuously enacted as people stop speaking with opponents, speak only about them, infer character from statements, demand public denunciation, and punish continued association. The present framework adds the **moral-closure hypothesis**:

Rudolf Bilz's formulation of human existence as **tribunal existence** and Odo Marquard's "tribunalization of modern lived reality" are neighbouring diagnoses of a condition in which persons are placed under pervasive accusation and pressure to justify their right to be as they are. The exact primary source for Bilz's formulation remains to be verified; it is retained here as a provenance lead rather than presented as established evidence for the mechanism.

```
group bundles around an argument
↓
non-bundlers are excluded
↓
belonging becomes membership among "good people"
↓
opposition becomes character defect
↓
an open society is converted into a closed community
↓
the closed community seeks dominance
```

The originating discussion connected this sequence with Ulrike Guérot's "bundling" description of a group organizing around an argument and excluding those who refuse to bundle, and with Ferdinand Tönnies's distinction between open societal association and closed community. That compound attribution still requires a primary-source audit. The diagram above is therefore Culture Mechanics' moral-closure hypothesis, not a definition attributed to Guérot, Tönnies, or an established general definition of fascism.

The originating **ideology-as-hallucination hypothesis** is stronger still: an ideology operating as a collectively protected hallucination cannot win through a reality-facing explanation of mechanisms and consequences and therefore tends to use discursive domination. On this hypothesis, moralization expresses fear—or, in the culpable case, knowledge—that the position would fail under fair conditions among equals. This is a definite and risky project hypothesis, not an established result of Andrick's book. It would be weakened by cases in which a position systematically moralizes strong opponents despite repeatedly prevailing under open, symmetrical, evidence-sensitive contest, or by evidence that the moralization is better explained without awareness or fear of argumentative weakness.

The enforcement–exclusion and violence repertoire The originating claim is:

Enforcement and exclusion are dual operations. Enforcement states or applies a condition of continued inclusion, standing, access, or permitted action; exclusion withdraws or denies these goods when the condition is not met.

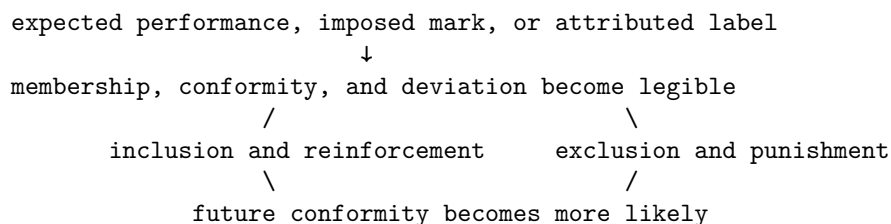
Andrick's compact threat—"Submit, or I will exclude you"—contains both sides. From the program's perspective, the rule is enforced. From the affected person's perspective, refusal can mean exclusion from moral standing, discussion, relationship, community, institution, territory, or life. The same sanction often does both simultaneously: excluding one visible nonconformist also enforces conformity among everyone who observes the consequence.

This is a structural duality, not an assertion that enforcement and exclusion are identical in every case. Instruction, persuasion, reward, or ordinary coordination can maintain a practice without applying an exclusionary sanction. A person can end a private relationship without trying to govern a wider public. Physical coercion can be used to retain or convert a person rather than expel them, although it excludes their alternative conduct and violates bodily autonomy. Jurisdiction, proportionality, evidence, due process, and the good being withheld remain separate questions.

The word *violence* must likewise not hide the difference between moral evaluation, discursive domination, exclusion, coercion, and bodily force:

Form	Program-side enforcement	Excluded standing or domain
Moral evaluation	Classifies conduct as good or bad; ordinary bigOther activity, not necessarily moralization	Moral approval or recognition as a good member; no civic or social exclusion need follow
Discursive violence	Replaces inquiry with character accusation and attacks the opponent's standing	Credibility, admissibility, or recognition as a legitimate interlocutor
Relational exclusion	Conditions or ends friendship, intimacy, or voluntary private association	A particular relationship or private circle
Collective social exclusion	Uses ostracism, cancellation, guilt by association, or coordinated reputational destruction	Community membership, social contact, reputation, and informal opportunities
Institutional coercion	Conditions employment, education, platforms, services, office, or professional standing on submission	Access to institutions, occupations, services, platforms, or public roles
Physical violence	Uses or threatens bodily force to compel, retain, punish, convert, expel, or eliminate	Bodily autonomy, movement, safety, territory, or the permitted alternative course of action
Eliminative violence	Treats the rival as having no right to remain, participate, or exist	Membership, territory, public existence, life, or memory

The conformity-signal mechanism is the sensor and this repertoire supplies possible outputs:



This repertoire is not a deterministic ladder. Moralization can stop at private withdrawal or social exclusion, and movements can jump to institutional or physical coercion. The compact distinction is:

All moralization is discursively violent in Andrick's sense; not all moralization expresses willingness to use physical violence. The fundamentalist threshold is authorization or willingness to use physical or eliminative force, not the mere presence of moral aggression.

Moralization can nevertheless raise the probability of further violence by turning the mistaken person into the bad person, licensing exclusion, making punishment appear deserved, and allowing aggression to be experienced as protection, justice, purification, or duty. This is a probabilistic escalation hypothesis, not the claim that every moralized disagreement becomes physically violent.

Stanton's genocidal escalation processes as a neighbouring model [Gregory H. Stanton's *Ten Stages of Genocide*](#) supplies a neighbouring model of how collective classification and symbolization can become organized eliminative violence. Stanton now emphasizes that the "stages" are overlapping, non-linear processes: they can operate simultaneously, need not advance inexorably, and can be interrupted. His object is the specific process leading to genocide; the culture-mechanical repertoire is broader and also applies to non-genocidal programs, relationships, institutions, and conflicts.

The models therefore map onto one another without becoming synonyms:

Stanton's process	Culture-mechanical relationship
1. Classification	The mythological lens divides a population into "us" and "them." Classification is upstream of violence and can also serve benign or necessary distinctions.

Stanton's process	Culture-mechanical relationship
2. Symbolization	Names, dress, documents, and other tokens make the classification socially legible. An expected conformity signal can target through its absence; an imposed marker such as the yellow star directly marks the out-group; an attributed label can do so without a worn object.
3. Discrimination	Enforcement–exclusion becomes durable law, custom, or institutional practice that removes rights, standing, access, or opportunity from the classified group.
4. Dehumanization	Moralized character accusation expands into categorical enemy construction: persons become vermin, disease, contamination, pollution, or another kind of being whose removal can be redescribed as cleansing or protection.
5. Organization	Parties, bureaucracies, police, armies, militias, media systems, lists, and surveillance turn hostility into scalable implementation capacity. Organization is infrastructure for violence, not by itself another form of violence.
6. Polarization	Moral closure, guilt by association, communicative severance, and attacks on moderates disable countercultures, compromise, and independent correction.
7. Preparation	Plans, target lists, training, weapons, mobilization, and euphemistic goals make organized physical or eliminative intent operational. These are strong indicators that the fundamentalist threshold has been crossed, although no numbered Stanton process defines that threshold.
8. Persecution	Institutional coercion and physical violence become coordinated identification, dispossession, arrest, displacement, confinement, torture, or killing of the target population.
9. Extermination	Genocide is a specific collective form of eliminative violence. The culture-mechanical category is broader because programs can seek to eliminate political, social, or other rivals without satisfying the definition of genocide.
10. Denial	The program protects itself after and during violence through euphemism, destroyed evidence, impunity, blame reversal, suppression of memory, and attacks on witnesses. This connects the enforcement–exclusion and violence repertoire to memory control and systemic lying in Epistemic Constitution of Lifted Mechanical Solidarity .

Stanton's model supplies historically developed observations and an early-warning process model. It does not establish the local-bigOther processor, distributed field, jealousy, or multi-mind-self ontology proposed here. Conversely, Culture Mechanics proposes a possible micro-to-macro mechanism through which some of Stanton's processes become affectively compelling, mutually observable, and institutionally executable.

The connection is a risky escalation hypothesis, not guilt by conceptual association. A classification, symbol, health rule, access condition, or act of private exclusion does not establish a genocidal trajectory. The inference becomes stronger only as additional processes appear: a sanctionable out-group, dehumanizing mythology, destruction of moderating relations, scalable coercive organization, preparation for physical force, persecution, and elimination. The absence of these transitions, durable protection of the target group's equal civic standing, and effective correction of wrongful classifications count against the escalation hypothesis.

Private morality and public standing The originating maxim “**morality is private**” protects an essential boundary: private moral revulsion does not by itself decide who may participate in public life. Taken absolutely, however, it would exclude genuine public moral questions and legitimate public authority. The compatible formulation is:

Comprehensive personal moral convictions do not by themselves determine another person’s civic standing. Public coercion requires publicly contestable rules, proper jurisdiction, evidence, proportionality, and due process.

Or, more vividly:

We may debate moral questions publicly, but disagreement must not become a character trial that revokes the opponent’s right to participate.

This boundary does not prohibit private association or moral judgment. It prevents a private moral law from silently becoming public jurisdiction. Its institutional development belongs in *Epistemic Constitution of Lifted Mechanical Solidarity*, especially “Low-cost contradiction, not low-cost condemnation.”

Worked examples and boundary tests **The DDR blue neckerchief.** The blue neckerchief of the Pioneer organization was not merely clothing or a membership badge. In a school environment where almost every child was expected to be a Pioneer, wearing it displayed conformity while the missing scarf exposed refusal without requiring the child to speak. The *historical description by MDR* records that Pioneer membership was part of ordinary school life and served the state’s socialist education. The culture-mechanical interpretation–boundary marker, identity and loyalty signal, public compliance device, and trigger for monitoring or sanction—is the present framework’s synthesis.

Speech and conduct. Prescribed gendered language (*Gendern*) can perform the same operation as cloth when use displays conformity, non-use becomes observable, and non-use is interpreted as character disclosure. A COVID mask can remain a medical device while also functioning as an ideological signal when the surrounding field makes it a visible test of responsibility, obedience, solidarity, distrust, or political allegiance. A salute, pledge, pronoun formula, badge, ribbon, flag, profile image, applause, whistle, silence, or continued association can likewise carry the operation. The test is functional and contextual, not material.

Kippah and Islamic veiling. The originating whole-religion comparison is deliberately asymmetric and testable. Judaism is hypothesized to be predominantly non-proselytizing and the kippah predominantly member-directed: its ordinary public meaning is the wearer’s observance and affiliation, not a demand that surrounding non-Jews adopt it. Islam, considered as a whole religious-cultural program, is hypothesized to be predominantly proselytizing and jealous. Islamic veiling can therefore function simultaneously as personal observance, internal conformity, outward propagation, and a claim to public moral jurisdiction. This classification concerns the operative canonical and institutional program and its aggregate trajectory; it does not assert that every Jew, Muslim, kippah wearer, or veiled woman understands or intends the complete operation.

On this hypothesis, veiling can become a **public threat** in a precise culture-mechanical sense: not because the fabric or every individual wearer issues a conscious threat, but because the surrounding program publicly represents a demand for wider jurisdiction and makes sanctions against eventual refusal predictable if that program becomes dominant. The kippah contrast predicts no comparable Judaism-wide apparatus for punishing refusal or compelling outsiders; evidence of such an apparatus would count against the comparison.

The blue neckerchief and Islamic veiling are thus proposed as **functional homologues** when both embody the program in everyday life, make conformity and refusal legible, distinguish good members from questionable ones, enable peer or institutional monitoring, normalize the underlying order, and reproduce it through public performance. Their differences concern propagation, jealousy, jurisdiction, and enforcement, not a categorical division between secular and religious symbols.

The boundary is not Iran. Police enforcement is the extreme implementation layer, not the beginning of a jurisdictional claim. The originating trajectory is:

practice presented as personal choice
↓
practice promoted as protection, dignity, or empowerment
↓
practice becomes a public model of proper conduct
↓
criticism is moralized as hostility or harm
↓

countercultures lose legitimate means of defence
 ↓
 institutions accommodate and reproduce the norm
 ↓
 nonconformity becomes socially or professionally costly
 ↓
 the norm acquires legal and police enforcement

The language of protection can create an asymmetric field: the advancing program expresses its demand as care, freedom, dignity, or safety while resistance is classified as prejudice or aggression. The program remains free to extend its norm, while countercultures are morally disarmed from defending their own order. This is the proposed **protection-framed jurisdictional manoeuvre**. It can emerge through many sincere participants without a central conspiracy. Only when the collective-agent threshold is met should it be attributed as an intentional manoeuvre of a multi-mind-self; below that threshold it remains an emergent operation of a program, solidarity field, and distributed bigOther.

Iran is proposed not as the boundary at which the problem begins but as an advanced realized form in which a religious prescription has captured state jurisdiction. The [United Nations Independent International Fact-Finding Mission on Iran](#) documents morality-police deployment, surveillance, arrests, prosecution, and forced pledges connected to mandatory hijab enforcement. The originating **end-state hypothesis** is conditional and categorical: for the relevant aggressively proselytizing and jealous Islamic movements in Western societies, success means defeating countercultures and acquiring sufficient institutional power; **if they succeed, Iran is the predicted end-state form**, in which promoted Islamic norms become compulsory public jurisdiction. Iran exhibits the predicted completed conversion; its existence does not by itself establish that every movement will succeed.

The religion-level hypothesis should be tested against canonical claims, mission and jihad doctrines, historical institutional trajectories, treatment of apostasy and criticism, freedom of rival religions, rules governing women's dress, and conduct after political dominance is obtained. It would be weakened by durable Muslim-majority orders possessing overwhelming cultural and political power while intrinsically protecting across generations:

- genuine freedom not to veil;
- conversion away from Islam and public criticism of Islam;
- rival religions and nonreligious life;
- equal civic standing independent of religious conformity;
- constitutional barriers preventing Islamic morality from becoming compulsory public law.

Judaism's contrasting classification is equally revisable: evidence of systematic outward conversion, expanding jurisdiction over non-Jews, or coercive enforcement of kippah observance would weaken the predominantly non-proselytizing, member-directed hypothesis. Whole religions may be classified. The scientific safeguard is precise scope, evidence, counterexamples, and falsifiability—not protective euphemism.

Combined mechanism and boundaries The mini-theory's central mechanism is:

jealous mythology defines exclusive loyalty
 ↓
 ideological symbol activates the installed program
 ↓
 conformity or targeting signal makes loyalty, refusal, or target status observable
 ↓
 deviation or target status is interpreted as character or category disclosure
 ↓
 moralization turns disclosure into accusation
 ↓
 mechanical solidarity distributes the judgment
 ↓
 systems impose exclusion, coercion, or violence
 ↓
 the program defends or expands its jurisdiction

This mechanism is not a claim that every symbol is a conformity or targeting signal, every conformity signal is jealous, every target classification is wrongful, every moral judgment is moralization, every ideological-form program is fundamentalist, or every distributed bigOther is a multi-mind-self. Each transition is a separate empirical question.

The theory predicts greater field synchronization and enforcement when signals are publicly observable, refusal or target status is morally interpreted, sanctions are credible, rival affiliation is treated as betrayal, and institutions preserve the resulting classifications. Evidence that these variables do not affect propagation, apparent consensus, retention, exclusion, or jurisdiction would weaken the mechanism.

9. First analogy: the computer with one PCI slot

The computer analogy presents the architecture in its simplest form.

Imagine a computer containing:

- a powerful general-purpose **CPU**;
- one **PCI slot**;
- a comparatively simple sentiment-classification card installed in that slot;
- a network interface through which the card exchanges signals with compatible cards.

The CPU performs complex computation. The PCI card does something much simpler: it assigns values to the CPU's current objects and possible outputs. It marks them, in effect, as attractive or aversive, honourable or shameful, legitimate or forbidden.

The card's simplicity is deceptive. If it can alter the CPU's priorities, error signals, and reward expectations, it can redirect the much more powerful processor. A simple evaluator can cause an extremely intelligent CPU to spend enormous resources defending a premise the evaluator has made emotionally non-negotiable.

The card runs a mythological lens shaped by many mythologies and potentially assembled from several compatible programming packages. Social signals usually do not install a whole new lens; they call mappings already present on the card. Because the machine has only one PCI slot, a rival card cannot simply be added beside the first, and there is no hidden runtime controller that ranks parallel cards. Compatible packages can extend the software on the installed card. An incompatible governing program must be rejected, or the incumbent program must be unbraided and a successor rebraided and installed on the one card.

This analogy makes the division of labour between the two processors easy to understand. Its limitation is that real human cognition is embodied, affective, interpretive, and less cleanly modular than a desktop computer.

10. Second analogy: Haidt's elephant with a wireless collar

The second analogy gives a closer picture of the proposed psychological operation.

Jonathan Haidt describes conscious reasoning as a **rider** sitting on an **elephant**. The elephant represents the large, fast, intuitive, emotional, and mostly nonconscious part of the mind. The rider represents the smaller conscious and verbal part that explains, plans, and sometimes guides the elephant, but frequently rationalizes where the elephant is already going.

Culture mechanics adds a **wireless collar** around the elephant's neck.

- The **elephant** is the person's intuitive, motivational, and largely nonconscious psychology.
- The **rider** is conscious verbal awareness and explicit reasoning.
- The **processor in the wireless collar** is the bigOther.
- The **program stored in the collar** is the mythological lens.
- The **mythologies** are the evaluated stories through which that program is trained and reinforced.
- The **wireless signals** are other people's expressions, symbols, slogans, rituals, approval, disapproval, and visible conduct.

The collar can produce social pleasure and pain: pride, shame, belonging, exclusion, sacredness, disgust, reassurance, fear, or indignation. It acts directly upon the elephant. The elephant changes its posture, attention, and direction long before the rider clearly notices the collar's intervention.

Only afterward may the rider become aware of a conclusion:

"This is obviously disgraceful."

"Someone like me cannot do that."

"Any decent person must support this."

The rider may mistake the resulting feeling for the product of independent reasoning. It may then use the main processor's verbal intelligence to justify the direction in which the elephant has already begun to move.

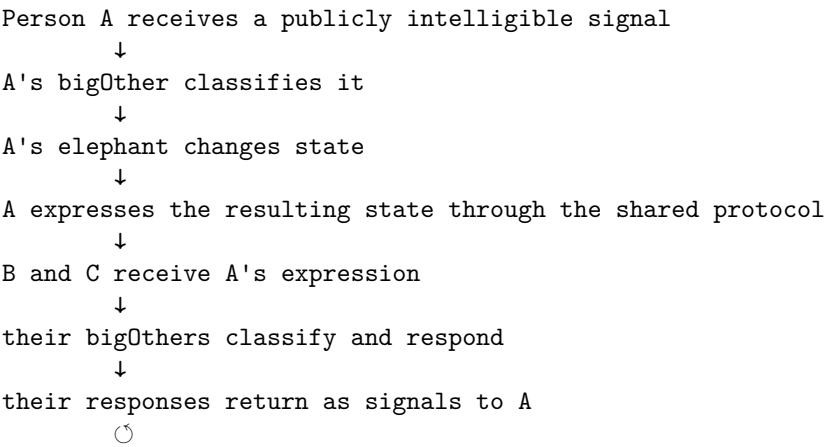
This analogy is closer to the psychological claim than the computer analogy because it shows that the bigOther does not normally dictate complete thoughts. It modifies the affective conditions under which thought and action occur. For the mapped features, non-inferences, and relationship of the CPU, PCI-slot, wireless-collar, protocol, and network pictures to the framework’s physical and craft analogies, see [Analogical Models in Culture Mechanics: A Semantic Inventory](#).

11. The wireless superpower: the individual coupling interface

The bigOther’s distinctive superpower is its capacity to participate in **distributed computing**. Every collar is both receiver and transmitter. There is no separate class of persons possessing the only transmitters. People emit social signals through:

- facial expression, posture, and tone;
- attention or deliberate inattention;
- laughter, applause, chanting, or silence;
- confidence, fear, disgust, or outrage;
- repetition of phrases;
- imitation and conformity;
- approval, ridicule, punishment, and protection;
- participation in or refusal of rituals.

These outputs become inputs for other collars:



The originating physical analogy is that a local bigOther resembles a charged particle: it is a source of a field and is simultaneously susceptible to the field produced by other sources. The comparison concerns relational architecture and back-action. It does not propose a new physical force or claim that social dynamics obey Maxwell’s equations.

When participants run sufficiently compatible mythological lenses and can observe one another, reciprocal feedback can produce rapid alignment. A crowd may begin to attend, feel, chant, fear, celebrate, condemn, or act as if it were one body. This is the individual-to-field handoff. The field’s topology, unequal transmitter gain, collective agency, and epistemic consequences belong to the detailed account in [Epistemic Agency under Mechanical Solidarity](#).

12. Local bigOther, symbolic protocol, and distributed field

Culture mechanics distinguishes five levels that must not be treated as synonyms:

Level	Meaning in culture mechanics
Lacan’s big Other	The shared symbolic order and, in the present functional translation, the on-the-wire protocol of language, law, roles, conventions, master signifiers, and recognized symbolic authority.
Local bigOther	The individual sentiment classifier that executes one installed mythological lens and transmits and receives through the shared protocol.

Level	Meaning in culture mechanics
Mechanical solidarity	Emergent field coherence generated as compatible local bigOthers repeatedly produce, observe, and answer common classifications and sentiments.
Distributed bigOther	The dynamically maintained symbolic-affective network state reproduced through local bigOthers, institutions, roles, practices, stories, and artifacts.
Multi-mind-self	The distributed system when it becomes sufficiently integrated and continuous to perceive, remember, judge, intend, own, and act as a collective agent. Not every crowd or mechanically solidary field reaches this threshold.

The relationship is generative rather than an equation:

```

LOCAL BIGOTHERS
sentiment classifiers executing installed lenses
      ↓ communicate through
SHARED SYMBOLIC PROTOCOL / LACANIAN BIG OTHER
      ↓ may generate
MECHANICAL-SOLIDARITY COHERENCE
      ↓ maintains
DISTRIBUTED BIGOTHER
      ↓ may become sufficiently integrated as
MULTI-MIND-SELF

```

The distributed bigOther consists of no single person or object. It is realized through language, expectations, public symbols, rituals, stories, institutions, roles, laws, artifacts, and the anticipated judgments of other people. It is implemented through individuals but, as an emergent relational organization, is not adequately explained as a mere list of independently formed individual psychologies.

The relation remains recursive:

```

DISTRIBUTED BIGOTHER
mythologies, institutions, symbols, rituals, expectations
      ↓ programs and activates
LOCAL BIGOTHERS
      ↓ influence
ELEPHANTS AND MAIN CPUs
      ↓ produce
PUBLIC SIGNALS AND INSTITUTIONAL PRACTICES
      ↓ reproduce or transform
DISTRIBUTED BIGOTHER
      ↻

```

Culture is neither wholly outside nor wholly inside the person. It is the comparatively stable pattern maintained by this circulation between local programming and distributed execution. First-order and **lifted mechanical solidarity** differ in the abstraction level of their shared classifications, not in this basic field-forming mechanism. *Epistemic Agency under Mechanical Solidarity* develops that distinction together with field geometry, collective ownership, gatekeepers, and back-action upon epistemic agency.

Nested authorship, activation, and episodic multi-mind-selves A multi-mind-self is a **network-level subject**, not a second local self or a second PCI card installed inside each participant. Collective and personal authorship can therefore coexist at different levels. The collective can legitimately perceive, remember, decide, own, and act as we while participating persons retain legitimate *Is*, differentiated functions, consciences, judgments, relationships, property, and bounded rights of refusal and exit.

A differentiated multi-mind-self adds an operative we without invalidating the participating *Is*. Fusion begins when the we displaces those *Is* as independently legitimate authors.

The definition is functional and emergent. It does not reduce the collective to a mere metaphor or list of individual states: the organized relation has continuing capacities and acts back upon its participants. It also does not by itself assert one unitary field of phenomenal consciousness analogous to a biological person's experience. Whether collective phenomenal subjectivity exists is a further and much harder claim than whether the distributed organization qualifies as an agent.

The relevant integration can have different temporal profiles. A continuing multi-mind-self may operate mainly through differentiated clockwork coordination and enter intermittent high-gain laser episodes. An **episodic multi-mind-self** crosses the collective-agent threshold only during bounded periods of sufficient common attention, coupling, reciprocal feedback, memory access, judgment, and coordinated action. Between episodes, institutions, calendars, roles, artifacts, places, stories, and trained local bigOthers may preserve a **latent distributed bigOther** below the presently active multi-mind-self threshold.

Calling this latency "sleep" is useful only when viable reactivation machinery and identity-bearing continuity remain. A de-animated remnant or culturally lost synchronization technology is not merely a sleeping collective self. The detailed state model and its pilgrimage, military, and Subak boundary cases belong to *Epistemic Agency under Mechanical Solidarity*, "Activation profiles and episodic multi-mind-selves".

Differentiated unity and subjecthood absorption (fusion) The existence or strength of a collective agent does not decide what standing its members retain. Culture mechanics calls a real shared **we** **differentiated unity** when distinct persons, functions, judgments, relationships, and legitimate subordinate jurisdictions remain constitutive parts of the common order. The qualifier **person-preserving unity** emphasizes the same boundary: unity is not mere coexistence, but neither does membership dissolve the participating subjects.

Subjecthood absorption (fusion) is the independent extent to which a collective program treats its members as organs whose personal judgment, conscience, purpose, property, loyalties, identity, relationships, refusal, or exit have no legitimate standing against the collectively enacted subject. Equivalently, fusion is the displacement or absorption of the person's self as an independently legitimate author, so that another enacted self increasingly perceives, judges, speaks, owns, and acts through that person. The person's biological body, main processor, skills, memory, and practical intelligence need not disappear; they can remain active as the collective subject's execution surface. The eye still sees, the mouth still speaks, and the hand still acts, but the collective claims the standing to determine for whom and for what they act.

Subjecthood absorption is not identical to high cultural interoperability, strong synchronization, multi-mind-self agency, comprehensive local slot occupancy, or a large jurisdiction. Those properties can contribute to it, but none defines it.

The principal dynamics increasing absorption are called **fusion pressure**:

- one selected alignment is generalized across more domains and maintained beyond the task or episode that made it useful;
- independent judgment and differentiated contribution are reclassified as noise, selfishness, alienation, impurity, or betrayal;
- personal, household, professional, associational, and institutional jurisdictions are subordinated to one collective purpose;
- the collective's classifications become compulsory while correction, refusal, exit, and appeal lose legitimate standing.

Total fusion is the limiting case: high subjecthood absorption combines with comprehensive jurisdiction and closed correction or exit. The originating image is that persons become "drops of water in one clear pond." It is a pole, not the definition of every multi-mind-self and not a biological state that humans can literally enter.

A **fusion ideology** is a mythology or program that treats the separate person as an incomplete, alienated, or falsely conscious fragment and seeks to reconstitute persons as organs of one collectively enacted subject with increasingly comprehensive jurisdiction. Such a program can demand fusion without succeeding in forming a competent multi-mind-self; conversely, a capable collective agent can remain differentiated, person-preserving, jurisdictionally bounded, and corrigible.

These distinctions add a **subjecthood-absorption axis** to analysis without altering the single-slot principle. Every participant still has one fully occupied local slot. The question is what standing the installed weave grants the person within the collective relation, not how many evaluators occupy that slot.

13. Symbolic reality

The bigOther does not merely evaluate an independently completed physical world. It also participates in creating **social reality**.

A piece of cloth becomes a flag. A person becomes a judge, citizen, traitor, hero, or martyr. An utterance becomes a promise, verdict, oath, insult, or declaration of war. A place becomes sacred. A relationship becomes a marriage. An individual becomes the bearer of rights and dignity.

These properties are not inherent physical properties, but neither are they merely private fantasies. They are real insofar as people and institutions collectively recognize and act upon them. Symbols, rituals, and authorized classifications therefore do not only represent society; their execution helps constitute society.

Culture mechanics calls attention to both directions:

1. society programs the local bigOther; and
2. locally classified action reproduces or transforms society.

14. The full culture-mechanical cycle

The complete process can be summarized as follows:

SLOW CULTURAL FORMATION AND PROGRAMMING
endogenous formation and/or attempted purposive construction
stories + symbols + systems + rituals
+ leadership + rewards + sanctions + experience

↓

MYTHOLOGIES
individual socially evaluated stories

↓

MYTHOLOGICAL LENS
the single local evaluative mapping program

↓

BIGOTHER
fast execution and sentiment classification

↓

ELEPHANT
attention + intuition + motivation + bodily readiness

↓

RIDER AND MAIN CPU
verbalization + explanation + planning + possible criticism

↓

VISIBLE ACTION AND COMMUNICATION

↓

ENCODING IN SHARED SYMBOLIC PROTOCOL
words + gestures + symbols + roles + sanctions

↓

OTHER LOCAL BIGOTHERS RECEIVE AND CLASSIFY

↓

COORDINATION, SYNCHRONIZATION, OR OPPOSITION

↓

RITUAL, CUSTOM, ROLE, INSTITUTION, OR EMERGENT FIELD

↓

REINFORCEMENT OR MODIFICATION OF MYTHOLOGIES,
LENSES, AND DISTRIBUTED BIGOTHER

⌚

This cycle deliberately stops at the individual-to-field boundary. [Epistemic Agency under Mechanical Solidarity](#) asks how the emergent field acts back upon judgment, distributes authority, and supports or suppresses epistemic agency.

15. Open and closed cultural programming

Culture mechanics is descriptive before it is normative. The same mechanisms can support an open society or a closed total community.

A **closed cultural program** forms a mythological lens that teaches the bigOther to reward:

- unanimity and obedience;
- one overriding identity;
- submission to a central authority;
- denunciation of deviants;
- conflation of factual truth with political loyalty;
- exclusion of competing institutions and sources;
- treatment of counterevidence as betrayal or pollution.

An **open cultural program** forms a mythological lens that teaches the bigOther to value second-order norms:

- every person possesses dignity;
- opponents remain legitimate members of society;
- disagreement is not automatically betrayal;
- respect for a person does not require agreement with every claim;
- evidence may correct belief;
- authority may be criticized;
- compromise can be honourable;
- multiple institutions and affiliations must remain independent;
- no person or institution may become the sole authorized voice of the bigOther.

On the single-slot model, pluralism does not mean having no shared programming or installing one independent evaluator for each affiliation. It means that one open weave can be a fully installed lifted meta-program whose shared generator admits different context-sensitive first-order outputs. Its concrete surface can vary without its authority being weaker or local: the binding sameness lies in the rules by which answers are generated, tested, applied, and revised. These rules are not a higher runtime judge ranking several bigOthers; generator and outputs form one weave. Detailed cases and boundary tests are developed in [Epistemic Agency under Mechanical Solidarity](#).

16. Autonomy, capture, and susceptibility

Culture mechanics does not define autonomy as the absence of a bigOther. Language, morality, identity, and social cooperation all require cultural formation. Nor is autonomy the installation of a second bigOther to overrule the first. The relevant question is whether the main processor can inspect and revise the one installed lens and the bigOther's classifications. Autonomy is therefore compatible with full capture: it names an operative weave whose binding rules protect the main processor's capacity to inspect and revise its classifications, not incomplete programming or escape from the slot.

In an autonomous configuration, a person can:

- distinguish affective certainty from evidence;
- notice shame, disgust, or group pressure as signals rather than proofs;
- compare inherited classifications with direct experience;
- tolerate disagreement and temporary dissonance;
- question the authority that supplied a classification;
- revise the mythological lens when its classifications contradict evidence or experience.

Every installed program governs classification, and a lifted program necessarily has meta-authority over first-order jurisdictions. **Pathological capture** begins not with governing authority as such but when the weave or its representatives become uncorrectable, monopolize authorized interpretation, exceed their constituted jurisdiction, or claim **epistemic sovereignty**—that reality must answer to authorization rather than authorization to reality. The bigOther then determines which perceptions, questions, relationships, and feelings the main CPU may treat as legitimate. Intelligence remains available, but is recruited to implement or defend the installed lens.

Full capture can integrate an already compatible package, but capture by an incompatible governing worldview requires replacement. Authorities, sanctions, rituals, relationships, and field back-action must loosen the incumbent weave's load-bearing bindings, make detachment or reinterpretation survivable, and help rebraid one successor. Conversely, counter-relations and reality contact can protect or repair the incumbent weave without acting as a

second evaluator. A rival successor is not pathological merely because it replaces an incumbent; its corrigibility and authority relations must be assessed independently.

Susceptibility to such capture is not treated as a single scalar trait. It can involve different degrees of:

- programmability through narratives and exemplars;
- sensitivity to approval, rejection, and unanimity;
- ease of synchronization with a group;
- identity dependence;
- affective charge and internalization;
- resistance to counterevidence;
- difficulty of reprogramming;
- practical ability to dissent or leave.

17. Synonyms and terminological neighbours of the bigOther

There is no established term that is an exact synonym for the **bigOther** as culture mechanics defines it. The term deliberately combines a local sentiment classifier, its culturally learned programming, its relation to the symbolic order, and its capacity for distributed synchronization. Existing concepts usually name only one of these aspects.

The closest everyday term is **conscience** (*Gewissen*), provided that it is understood as an affectively active moral evaluator rather than as a little rational judge inside the mind. Conscience marks conduct and even contemplated conduct with approval, guilt, shame, obligation, or prohibition. In that respect it performs part of the bigOther's sentiment-classification function.

Conscience is nevertheless narrower than the bigOther. The bigOther also classifies status, belonging, legitimacy, loyalty, sacredness, pollution, identity, and social danger, including cases that are not ordinarily described as matters of conscience. Conversely, conscience can include deliberate moral reflection performed by the main CPU, whereas the bigOther refers specifically to the fast culturally programmed evaluator that influences such reflection. Culture mechanics can therefore distinguish a **socially authored conscience**, whose judgments are largely supplied by the surrounding field, from a more **self-authored conscience**, whose inherited classifications can be examined and deliberately endorsed, rejected, or revised.

Neighbouring term	Main overlap with the bigOther	Important difference
Lacan's big Other	The prior symbolic order of language, law, roles, authority, and socially intelligible meaning; functionally, the shared protocol through which local states become publicly legible.	It is the source term, but Lacan did not describe a literal local co-processor, PCI card, or the full on-the-wire analogy. Culture mechanics adds that implementation and translation.
James's felt objective presence	A reality or unseen order may be experienced as objectively present and conduct-directing.	It illuminates bigOther-presence phenomenologically but does not specify its local processor, cultural program, or network mechanism.
Buber's I-Thou relation	Another is encountered in a second-person relational mode rather than as an object.	It illuminates bigOther-as-Thou but must not be reduced to social programming; Buber's eternal Thou is not the culture-mechanical bigOther.
Conscience / Gewissen	Internal moral approval, guilt, shame, obligation, and prohibition.	It is the closest ordinary-language partial synonym, but is narrower than the bigOther and can also include reflective moral judgment by the CPU.
Superego	Internalized authority, prohibitions, ideals, guilt, and demands placed upon the self.	It emphasizes a psychoanalytic intrapsychic agency, often especially its punitive aspect; it does not by itself denote the full symbolic network or distributed computation.

Neighbouring term	Main overlap with the bigOther	Important difference
Generalized other	George Herbert Mead's organized attitudes and expectations of a community that a person learns to take toward the self.	It closely describes the social standpoint represented locally, but not the proposed dual-processor architecture or its primitive affective interface.
Collective conscience / collective consciousness	Durkheim's shared beliefs and sentiments, with their moral authority over group members.	It is closest to the distributed bigOther; it does not isolate the local sentiment-classification unit through which collective sentiments become personally operative.
Internalized norms, moral schemas, and moral identity	Learned evaluative rules, expectations, and identity commitments.	These are components of the mythological lens executed by the bigOther rather than names for the processor, the narrative corpus, and the network together.
Habitus	Social history embodied as durable perception, feeling, and action dispositions.	It is broader than moral-social classification and does not posit a single-slot evaluator or a separate general-purpose CPU.
Socialized mind and ego development	Describe developmental relations to social expectations, internal standards, and one's own meaning-making system.	They describe organizations or levels of the whole person, not an additional processor. They are developmental neighbours of the bigOther, not synonyms for it.

The vocabulary should therefore be used with the following rule:

Conscience, superego, generalized other, collective conscience, felt objective presence, and I-Thou relation each illuminate an aspect of the bigOther; none alone names the complete culture-mechanical construct.

18. Development of the bigOther: Kegan and Loevinger

Culture mechanics treats the bigOther as developmentally variable. A person is not born with a completed mythological lens. Social evaluation is first encountered through attachment, imitation, direct reward and punishment, and dependence on caregivers. It is then internalized as group-authored conscience and may later become available for self-authorship and reflective revision.

[Robert Kegan's constructive-developmental theory](#) and [Jane Loevinger's ego-development research](#) provide the closest developmental models found in the surrounding conversations, but neither proposed a bigOther. Kegan's subject-object theory describes increasingly complex **forms of mind** or **meaning-making**, not merely moral conscience. Loevinger's theory describes development of the **ego** across impulse control, character, interpersonal understanding, conscious preoccupations, and moral evaluation. The culture-mechanical model below is consequently a synthesis and translation, not a claim that either theorist described the wireless collar.

The key developmental question is:

Is the mythological lens something the person can look at and revise, or is it the unquestioned lens through which the person looks?

This is Kegan's subject-object distinction applied specifically to cultural sentiment classification. What remains **subject** to a person has the person: it organizes experience but cannot yet be examined as an object. What becomes **object** can be noticed, compared, evaluated, and acted upon. Development of the bigOther therefore does not primarily mean that the collar becomes stronger. It means that the homo-duplex system gains a more complex and reflective relation to the lens stored in the collar.

A four-phase culture-mechanical model

Culture-mechanical phase	Closest Keganian neighbour	Closest Loevingerian neighbour	Relation to the bigOther
1. Installation and external regulation	Impulsive and instrumental forms of mind	Impulsive and Self-Protective stages	Social control is experienced mainly through immediate attachment, advantage, reward, retaliation, and punishment. A stable moral-social lens is still being installed; much of its authority remains visibly outside the person.
2. Socially authored bigOther	Socialized Mind	Conformist and transitional Self-Aware levels	Group expectations, authorities, relationships, and accepted roles become internally binding. The person can subordinate impulse to shared rules, but has difficulty standing apart from the social field that defines what ought to feel admirable, shameful, loyal, or forbidden. Borrowed judgment is experienced as one's own obvious conscience.
3. Self-authored bigOther	Self-Authoring Mind	Conscientious stage	The person constructs an internal code and can use it to evaluate competing external demands. The main CPU can identify, endorse, and deliberately revise at least some mappings in the installed lens. The bigOther remains present, but its lens is increasingly governed from within rather than continuously authored by the current group.
4. Self-transforming bigOther	Self-Transforming Mind	Individualistic transition, Autonomous stage, and the rare Integrated stage	The person can take even a self-authored value system as object, recognize its partial and constructed character, tolerate conflicts among frameworks, and revise the meta-rules by which classifications are made. The lens can include its own corrigibility without dissolving all commitments.

These are correspondences, not one-to-one equations. In particular, Loevinger's **Conscientious** stage is not simply "having a conscience"; it is a comparatively developed organization characterized by self-evaluated standards, responsibility, long-term goals, and evaluation of rules rather than mere acceptance of group rules. Her **Individualistic**

level is a transition from Conscientious to Autonomous, and the Autonomous and Integrated levels add tolerance of inner conflict, ambiguity, interdependence, and increasingly integrated identity. Kegan describes a related shift in different terms: from being authored by relationships and the surrounding culture, to authoring an internal system, to being able to inspect the limitations of that system itself.

Development under the single-slot principle Development does not install additional bigOthers beside the first one. The computer still has one PCI slot, one operative sentiment-classification architecture, and therefore one fully occupied slot. What changes is the person's relation to the installed card and, during lifting, the order of the rules it runs:

EXTERNALLY ENFORCED LENS

the environment supplies immediate reward and punishment

↓

SOCIALLY AUTHORED LENS

the group's judgments operate internally as obvious conscience

↓

SELF-AUTHORED LENS

the person can evaluate social demands through an internal code

↓

SELF-TRANSFORMING LENS

the person can inspect and revise even the code and its meta-rules

A self-transforming person can represent several moral systems in the main CPU, translate between them, and understand each from within. This does not require several PCI cards running independently or a higher evaluator that ranks them at runtime. Until reconstruction occurs, one local bigOther still executes one operative lens. The developmental achievement is that the person can treat this present lens as partial, corrigible, and open to deliberate repair, compatible extension, unbraiding, or replacement.

Self-transformation can therefore unbraid a first-order program whose concrete answers are treated as final and rebraid one lifted program in which binding meta-rules generate, select, apply, and revise concrete answers. First-order religious, professional, familial, political, or local packages need not vanish; their particular rules and conclusions remain within the successor weave as outputs or bounded packages answerable to its generator. This is full lifted capture, not a neutral evaluator standing above culture.

Nor does greater autonomy require disconnection from distributed computing. The socially authored person is especially liable to be synchronized by whichever reference group carries authority. The self-authoring person can choose commitments and networks from an internal standpoint. The self-transforming person can participate in collective life without assuming that any single network exhausts reality, and can sometimes translate between networks without simply fusing with either one.

The “less than 1%” claim The recollection that the most developed Keganian form occurs in fewer than one percent of adults is supported, with an attribution caveat. A peer-reviewed account by Lars Bauger, Rob Bongaardt, and Jack J. Bauer reports that, **according to Kegan and Lahey (2009)**, approximately 80–90% of adults make meaning between the Socialized and Self-Authoring levels, while the Self-Transforming Mind is “seldom seen (less than 1%).” The estimate is therefore appropriately attributed to **Kegan and Lahey’s framework**, while the directly checkable wording appears in [Bauger, Bongaardt, and Bauer’s 2021 article](#).

This figure should be treated as a reported developmental estimate, not as a population census, a biological constant, or a direct measurement of the bigOther. It concerns Kegan’s highest whole-person meaning-making structure. Culture mechanics translates that structure into the capacity to take one’s own mythological lens as object; it does not claim that Kegan measured a collar processor or that exactly the same percentage applies across all societies and methods.

Developmental cautions Developmental complexity is not identical to intelligence, factual correctness, kindness, mental health, or moral worth. A powerful CPU does not guarantee a self-authored relation to the bigOther. Conversely, a self-authored person can construct and defend a cruel or epistemically contaminated code. Development describes increasing capacity to author and inspect a framework; the content and consequences of that framework must still be evaluated independently.

The highest phase should also not be understood as the disappearance of conscience. Its defining feature is **reflective ownership without finalization**: the person can retain commitments, feel moral sentiments, and participate in a

culture while knowing that the framework producing those classifications is neither infallible nor complete.

19. Cross-references to closely related concepts

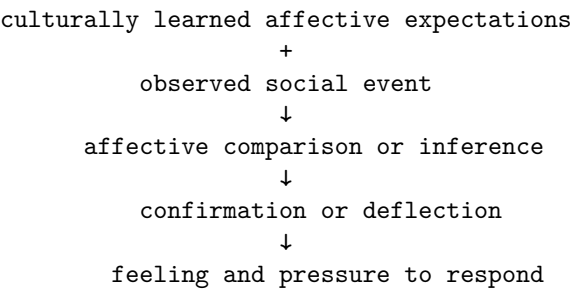
The following concepts overlap with parts of culture mechanics without being synonyms for the theory as a whole.

Affect Control Theory and BayesACT **Affect Control Theory** (ACT) and its probabilistic extension **BayesACT** provide a formal computational neighbour to the culture-mechanical account of the mythological lens. ACT models culturally learned affective meanings—called **fundamental sentiments**—attached to identities, actions, and settings. An observed social event produces a **transient impression**, which is compared with these culturally expected meanings. The resulting discrepancy is called **deflection**. Deflection generates pressure toward emotion, reinterpretation, identity adjustment, or corrective action that restores affective consistency.

The correspondence is:

Culture mechanics	ACT/BayesACT
Mythological lens	Culturally learned fundamental sentiments and impression-formation rules.
Real-world observation or event	An observed actor–behaviour–object event producing a transient impression.
bigOther classification	Comparison of the transient meaning with culturally expected meaning.
Affective signal	Confirmation or deflection—the discrepancy between expected and observed meaning.
Resulting response	Emotion, reinterpretation, identity adjustment, or corrective action.

[BayesACT](#) adds uncertain beliefs about identities and situations, Bayesian updating, explicit goals, and decision-theoretic action selection. In culture-mechanical terms, it offers one possible formalization of how an installed cultural mapping could combine with an observation to produce affective confirmation or error and consequent pressure on feeling and action:



This is a cross-reference rather than a foundation of culture mechanics. ACT and BayesACT do not propose a separate bigOther, a single PCI slot, mythological narrative programming, or distributed synchronization. They also do not explain how mythologies initially form the mythological lens. BayesACT’s instrumental action selection extends beyond the primitive sentiment-classification function assigned to the collar and overlaps with planning functions that culture mechanics assigns to the main CPU.

Stanovich’s rationality framework Keith E. Stanovich, Richard F. West, and Maggie E. Toplak distinguish rationality from intelligence and describe cognition with a **tripartite model**:

- The **autonomous mind** produces rapid, automatic, highly practised, or evolutionarily prepared responses.
- The **algorithmic mind** supplies computational capacity for sustained processing, inhibition, and cognitive simulation. Conventional intelligence tests primarily track capacities at this level.
- The **reflective mind** concerns goals, epistemic values, thinking dispositions, and the decision to initiate reflective processing or override a default response.

This tripartite division should not be mapped one-to-one onto homo duplex. In culture mechanics, all three Stanovichian minds describe operations performed within the ordinary brain—the main cognitive system represented

by the CPU, elephant, and rider. The bigOther is an additional functional distinction: a culturally programmable sentiment classifier coupled to that system.

The most faithful architectural mapping is:

Stanovichian term	Function in Stanovich's model	Closest culture-mechanical location
Autonomous mind	Generates fast default responses	Part of the main brain and especially the elephant; it is influenced by, but is not identical to, the bigOther.
Algorithmic mind	Supplies computational power, decoupling, inhibition, and simulation	The processing power of the main CPU.
Reflective mind	Establishes goals and epistemic dispositions and initiates override	The governing and self-corrective activity of the main CPU, represented partly by the rider.
Mindware	Provides learned knowledge, rules, procedures, and strategies for reasoning	General acquired programming available to the main CPU; mythologies may carry mindware, while their culturally evaluative lessons can be compiled into the bigOther's mythological lens.

This prevents two misleading equations:

The autonomous mind is **not** the bigOther.

Mindware in general is **neither a mythology nor the mythological lens**.

Probability theory, falsification, causal reasoning, and decision rules are mindware used by the main CPU without necessarily belonging to the bigOther. A mythology is a culturally evaluated story and may carry many kinds of mindware. The mythological lens is narrower than mindware in general: it is the mapping distilled from many mythologies that organizes social identity and sentiment classification.

Mindware gaps and other rationality failures A **mindware gap** exists when a person lacks a learned rule or body of knowledge required for rational judgment. Someone may possess ample algorithmic capacity but not understand base rates, regression to the mean, falsification, or probabilistic reasoning. In culture-mechanical language, the main CPU is powerful enough, but lacks the corrective program needed to evaluate or override a default response.

Stanovich's taxonomy separates this from several other failures:

Failure	Stanovichian description	Culture-mechanical translation
Cognitive miserliness	Reflective processing is not initiated; an easy default is accepted.	The CPU does not spend the effort needed to inspect the elephant's response or the collar's classification.
Override failure	Reflective processing begins and relevant mindware exists, but the default response is not successfully suppressed.	The CPU detects a problem but fails to overcome the elephant's or bigOther's strongly weighted response.
Mindware gap	The alternative knowledge or rule needed for a rational response is absent or insufficiently learned.	The CPU lacks the epistemic tool needed to correct the response.
Contaminated mindware	Acquired mindware itself causes irrational belief or action.	In the culture-mechanical use developed here, the bigOther executes a defective lens that generates misdirecting sentiments and protects its mappings from evaluation.

These failures can combine. A contaminated bigOther may discourage the reflective mind from initiating inspection, make affective override more difficult, and prevent missing corrective mindware from being learned.

Contaminated mindware as a badly programmed bigOther In Stanovich's framework, **contaminated mindware** is acquired mindware that directly causes irrational belief or action—either by reducing epistemic accuracy or by thwarting effective goal pursuit. It can include superstitious thinking, antiscience attitudes, conspiracy beliefs, dysfunctional personal beliefs, misleading causal models, and culturally conditioned misinformation.

Stanovich gives special attention to mindware containing **evaluation-disabling properties**. Such mindware keeps itself lodged in a host by attaching punishment to questioning, rewarding unquestioning acceptance, or making itself unfalsifiable. This aspect provides the strongest direct bridge to culture mechanics because punishment, reward, and protected sacredness are operations of the bigOther's sentiment-classification system.

Following the present theory's guidance, culture mechanics adopts the term in this more specific functional sense:

Contaminated mindware is a badly programmed bigOther: contaminated mythologies have shaped a defective mythological lens whose classifications attach strong sentiments to thoughts and evidence in ways that systematically misguide the main CPU.

The defective lens may mark:

- a false claim as sacred truth;
- honest doubt as betrayal;
- reliable evidence as enemy contamination;
- asymmetric scrutiny as moral vigilance;
- cruelty as righteous duty;
- correction as humiliation or surrender;
- loyalty to a source as a substitute for evaluating its claims.

The contamination lies in both **content** and **control**. Individual mythologies can carry misleading claims, roles, causal explanations, or anti-evaluation procedures. Repetition compiles those lessons into a defective lens, while the bigOther executes the lens and thereby determines how entertaining, questioning, revising, or rejecting them feels. Pride, shame, sacredness, belonging, authority, disgust, fear, and anticipated punishment protect the defective lens.

The resulting causal sequence is:

```
CONTAMINATED BIGOTHER PROGRAMMING
misleading mythologies + evaluation-disabling procedures
      ↓
DEFECTIVE MYTHOLOGICAL LENS
misdirected mappings from observations to values and feelings
      ↓
STRONG AFFECTIVE MISCLASSIFICATION
false feels sacred, doubt feels disloyal,
harm feels righteous, correction feels shameful
      ↓
REFLECTIVE INHIBITION OR FAILED OVERRIDE
the CPU does not inspect, cannot overcome, or lacks corrective mindware
      ↓
MOTIVATED OR MYSIDE REASONING
selective search, asymmetric scrutiny, rationalization, and defence
      ↓
IRRATIONAL BELIEF OR ACTION
reduced epistemic accuracy or frustrated goal attainment
```

The phrase “wrong direction” should be tied to Stanovich's standards of rationality rather than merely to disagree with an observer. A bigOther is contaminated when its lens systematically impairs:

- **epistemic rationality:** forming beliefs that are appropriately calibrated to evidence and reality; or
- **instrumental rationality:** acting effectively in pursuit of the person's considered goals.

Political, religious, or moral disagreement alone is not evidence of contaminated mindware. The diagnosis requires such features as demonstrable epistemic failure, goal-thwarting consequences, asymmetric standards, or procedures

that disable evaluation.

The extension and its boundary The synchronization can now be stated precisely:

- **Stanovich supplies the cognitive pathology:** harmful acquired knowledge and strategies can cause irrationality even when computational intelligence is adequate.
- **Culture mechanics assigns that pathology a location in its dual architecture:** when contaminated mindware is cultural, identity-laden, and affectively enforced, it becomes part of a defective mythological lens executed by the bigOther.
- **Culture mechanics adds a causal interface:** the contaminated bigOther misguides the main CPU by attaching strong feelings to its thoughts and possible conclusions.
- **Culture mechanics adds a distributed mechanism:** networked bigOthers reward, punish, repeat, and synchronize contaminated mythologies and lens mappings across people.
- **Motivated or myside reasoning is usually downstream:** the main CPU is recruited to protect the direction already weighted by the bigOther.

This is a faithful extension, not a claim that Stanovich proposed a bigOther, a wireless collar, homo duplex, or distributed cultural computation. His category is broader: contaminated mindware need not always be socially synchronized or strongly affective. Culture mechanics deliberately concentrates on the subset for which the acquired contamination has entered the mythological lens of the sentiment classifier.

Conversely, not every mythology produces contaminated mindware, and no single story normally determines an entire lens. Mythologies can instead teach intellectual honesty, falsifiability, evidential symmetry, uncertainty, and willingness to revise. An open culture can thereby form a lens that makes reality-oriented conduct feel honourable and correction tolerable rather than misdirecting the CPU away from them.

Dysrationalia **Dysrationalia** is Stanovich's term for irrational thought or behaviour despite adequate intelligence. It is closely related to the homo-duplex thesis because it rejects the assumption that a powerful main CPU guarantees rational judgment.

Culture mechanics proposes one possible social-affective pathway to dysrationalia: the bigOther can set priorities, prohibit questions, or make accurate revision socially painful while leaving general intelligence intact. Dysrationalia is nevertheless broader. It can also result from mindware gaps, cognitive miserliness, poor thinking dispositions, or failures to initiate reflective processing.

Motivated reasoning **Motivated reasoning** is the tendency for desired conclusions, identities, loyalties, or emotional needs to influence how evidence is sought, interpreted, remembered, and evaluated.

In culture mechanics, motivated reasoning is not itself the bigOther. It is what the main CPU may do after the bigOther has marked one conclusion as honourable, safe, identity-preserving, or socially rewarded and another as shameful, dangerous, or disloyal. The CPU's power can then increase the sophistication of the rationalization rather than correct its direction.

Not every instance of reasoning from one's existing perspective is irrational. Prior beliefs may deserve evidential weight, and revising an established model has real cognitive costs. The culture-mechanical concern is the narrower case in which the bigOther enforces asymmetric or evaluation-disabling treatment of evidence and thereby reduces epistemic or instrumental rationality.

Identity-protective cognition **Identity-protective cognition** is motivated reasoning specifically directed toward protecting membership, status, or alignment within an identity-defining group. It is one of the closest empirical neighbours of the wireless-collar model.

The bigOther supplies an internalized audience and asks, in effect:

What would accepting this evidence say about who I am, whose side I am on, and whether I still belong?

The person may consequently reject an accurate conclusion not because it exceeds the main CPU's capacity, but because accepting it would trigger shame, loss of status, or symbolic expulsion.

Moral conviction, sacred values, and taboo trade-offs **Moral conviction** occurs when a preference or belief is experienced as a matter of fundamental right and wrong rather than negotiable interest. A **sacred value** is protected from ordinary comparison or exchange. A **taboo trade-off** is a comparison whose mere consideration is treated as morally offensive.

These concepts describe classifications produced by the bigOther when it assigns exceptional moral authority to an object or rule. They help explain why compromise can feel like corruption and why cost-benefit reasoning can provoke outrage rather than deliberation. They also distinguish an ordinary strong preference from programming that determines what the main CPU is permitted even to compare.

Actively open-minded thinking and epistemic autonomy **Actively open-minded thinking** is the disposition to search for reasons one may be wrong, consider alternatives, apply standards symmetrically, and revise beliefs in response to evidence. It is a form of healthy mindware and a partial operational counterpart to what culture mechanics calls **epistemic autonomy**.

Epistemic autonomy does not require the absence of a bigOther. It requires a mythological lens that permits the main CPU to inspect the bigOther's outputs and that does not convert doubt, correction, or uncertainty automatically into shame and betrayal.

Actively open-minded thinking predicts resistance to many reasoning errors and forms of contaminated mindware, but it should not be treated as a universal antidote. Stanovich's work finds myside bias unusually resistant to prediction by intelligence and, in several paradigms, by actively open-minded-thinking measures themselves.

Master signifiers In Lacanian terminology, a **master signifier** is a privileged signifier that organizes other meanings and identifications. Words such as *Nation, Justice, Science, Tradition, Safety, Freedom, or Revolution* can function in this way.

A master signifier is not inherently contaminated. It becomes a carrier of contaminated mindware when invoking it terminates evaluation rather than organizing an inquiry—for example, when “Science” changes from the name of a corrigible method into an authority token that makes further judgment impermissible.

In the wireless-collar and protocol analogies, a master signifier is a **highly compressed protocol token**. It indexes a large package of already installed mythologies, classifications, authorities, identities, sentiments, and expected conduct without restating them. This explains both its efficiency and its danger: participants can coordinate through a short token, but the expansion it activates may remain unspoken and therefore difficult to inspect.

Bonhoeffer's Dummheit Dietrich Bonhoeffer's 1943 reflection “[Von der Dummheit](#)” ([PDF of the complete section](#)) is the starting point of the culture-mechanics theory. It posed the originating questions: **What causes this Dummheit? How does it work?**

The German original reads:

Jede starke äußere Machtentfaltung, sei sie politischer oder religiöser Art, schlägt einen großen Teil der Menschen mit Dummheit. Ja, es hat den Anschein, als sei das geradezu ein soziologisch-psychologisches Gesetz. Die Macht der einen braucht die Dummheit der anderen. Der Vorgang ist dabei nicht der, dass bestimmte – also etwa intellektuelle – Anlagen des Menschen plötzlich verkümmern oder ausfallen, sondern dass unter dem überwältigenden Eindruck der Machtentfaltung dem Menschen seine innere Selbständigkeit geraubt wird und dass dieser nun – mehr oder weniger unbewusst – darauf verzichtet, zu den sich ergebenden Lebenslagen ein eigenes Verhalten zu finden. Dass der Dumme oft bockig ist, darf nicht darüber hinwegtäuschen, dass er nicht selbständig ist. **Man spürt es geradezu im Gespräch mit ihm, dass man es gar nicht mit ihm selbst, mit ihm persönlich, sondern mit über ihn mächtig gewordenen Schlagworten, Parolen etc. zu tun hat. Er ist in einem Bann, er ist verblendet, er ist in seinem eigenen Wesen missbraucht, misshandelt.** So zum willenlosen Instrument geworden, wird der Dumme auch zu allem Bösen fähig sein und zugleich unfähig, dies als Böses zu erkennen. Hier liegt die Gefahr eines diabolischen Missbrauchs.

The English translation used here is:

Every powerful display of external force, whether political or religious, strikes a large portion of people with stupidity. Indeed, it appears to be almost a sociological-psychological law: the power of the few needs the stupidity of the many. The process does not consist of certain intellectual faculties suddenly withering. Rather, under the overwhelming impression of power, people are robbed of their

inner independence and - more or less unconsciously - give up forming their own judgments about the situations that arise. The fact that the stupid person is often obstinate should not hide the reality that he is not acting autonomously. **In conversation one senses that one is not dealing with the person himself but with slogans and catch-phrases that have gained mastery over him. He is under a spell, blinded, his very being abused and misused.** Having become a will-less instrument, the stupid person is capable of any evil and at the same time incapable of recognizing it as evil. Here lies the danger of a diabolical misuse.

This is not a claim about low intelligence. Bonhoeffer describes a socially induced loss of inner independence in which external power, slogans, and formulas speak through a person whose ordinary intellectual abilities remain available. His *Dummheit* is therefore broader and more political than contaminated mindware.

Bonhoeffer names the phenomenon; culture mechanics proposes a mechanism. At the individual level, an intelligent person's main CPU can remain capable while the bigOther supplies the classifications, slogans, sentiments, and permissions under which that intelligence operates. [Epistemic Agency under Mechanical Solidarity](#) develops the social-field account: mutually synchronized local bigOthers and institutional power can make borrowed judgment feel internally compulsory and thereby weaken the person's capacity to form an independent response.

The historical baseline and the theoretical application must remain distinct. The [United States Holocaust Memorial Museum's biographical account](#) documents Bonhoeffer's theological and ecumenical activity, opposition to Nazi church policy, connections to resistance, and 1943 arrest. Its broader account of [non-Jewish resistance](#) also distinguishes individual theologians such as Bonhoeffer from church hierarchies that supported or acquiesced in the regime. Those facts do not directly measure anyone's local bigOther or establish the mechanism proposed below.

The **culture-mechanical application hypothesis** is that Bonhoeffer's one local bigOther executed a densely braided Christian mythological lens to which he was deeply loyal. That Christian weave could incorporate compatible packages such as a *Berufsethos*, familial responsibility, intellectual discipline, pastoral duty, and responsibility toward the concrete neighbour. They did not stand beside Christianity as independent evaluators or compete with it for supremacy; their operative meaning was produced within the one Christianly programmed weave.

National Socialism did not offer one more compatible package. On the originating verdict stated in "The single-slot principle," its governing classifications were deeply incompatible with an intact Christian weave. Nazi capture would therefore have required replacement rather than ranking:

INCUMBENT CHRISTIAN BRAID

God, truth, neighbour, church, obedience, responsibility, practice

↓

LOOSEN AND UNBRAID LOAD-BEARING BINDINGS

detach authorities, meanings, loyalties, sentiments, and defences

↓

LIMINAL INSTABILITY OR DEPENDENCY

the old weave no longer governs coherently; a successor is not yet secure

↓

REBRAID RETAINED AND NEW STRANDS

bind Christian remnants, Volk, race, Führer, nation, ritual, and sanction

↓

ONE NAZI-GOVERNED SUCCESSOR WEAVE

Where such capture succeeded in a pastor or priest, continued use of scripture, Christian vocabulary, ritual, office, or self-description would not by itself show that an intact Christian program survived below a higher-ranked Nazi program. The material could have been detached from its previous relations and rewoven into one Nazi-Christian successor lens. Whether and how this occurred in any particular person remains a historical and biographical question, not something the theory may infer from conformity alone.

The corresponding hypothesis about Bonhoeffer is that this unbraiding did not succeed. His deep loyalty, theological work, Christian practice, relationships, alternative authorities, and encounters with persecuted people may have maintained or repaired the incumbent braid. A supporting counterfield did not provide a second PCI card; it helped the installed Christian programming resist loosening and replacement. National Socialist signals could consequently be classified through that existing weave as idolatry, falsehood, or injury to the concrete neighbour rather than being processed as commands from a higher-ranked political identity. This is a proposed explanation of the historical contrast, not a direct measurement of Bonhoeffer's inner architecture or proof about clergy as a class.

Culture mechanics interprets Dummheit as a condition in which:

1. the bigOther has acquired meta-authority;
2. contaminated mindware—that is, defective mythologies and lens mappings—supplies protected beliefs, misdirected sentiments, and anti-evaluation rules;
3. social power supplies rewards, sanctions, repetition, and apparent consensus; and
4. the main CPU is recruited to execute and defend the resulting classifications.

Normopathie and political ponerology: two faces of captured culture Culture mechanics treats **Normopathie** and **political ponerology** as complementary perspectives on a captured cultural system. They are not identical concepts. They describe the same pathological configuration from different social positions:

- **Normopathie** describes the population-side result. People over-adapt to a pathological social normality and cease to recognize it as pathological. Their local bigOthers defer to authorities, prestige sources, reference groups, and apparent consensus; borrowed classifications may then crystallize into moral emotions and eventually feel like an autonomous conscience.
- **Political ponerology** describes the formation and exploitation of destructive political power. Its concepts of **spellbinders**, ponerogenic processes, and **pathocracy** provide the more precise elite-side vocabulary: manipulative, characterologically destructive, or cynically instrumental actors create, capture, intensify, administer, and profit from a pathological cultural order.

The two faces belong to one culture-mechanical “coin”: a **captured distributed bigOther**. On one face are the people living under its spell; on the other are the spellbinders and seducers who shape, exploit, and gain power from it.

SPELLBINDERS AND PATHOCRATIC ACTORS

select and manipulate mythologies, symbols, systems, and sanctions



CAPTURED MYTHOLOGICAL LENS / DISTRIBUTED BIGOTHER

defines normality, virtue, loyalty, danger, and deviance



NORMOPATHIC ADAPTATION

borrowed judgment, conformity, Dummheit, denunciation, self-policing



APPARENT CONSENSUS AND DISTRIBUTED ENFORCEMENT

reward the spellbinders and strengthen their control



Systems Leadership identifies important channels through which this capture can occur. Systems, symbols, leadership behaviour, and mythologies can be selected or modified so that the resulting mythological lens maps obedience to virtue, dissent to betrayal, dependence to safety, and elite interest to the common good. Political seduction then substitutes identification and affective trust for examination: the seducer offers protection, belonging, moral certainty, or relief from responsibility while seeking access, loyalty, power, and impunity.

The normopathically adapted population is therefore not merely passive. Once local bigOthers have been synchronized, ordinary participants become the distributed execution and enforcement layer of the captured bigOther. They repeat its mythologies, display its classifications, reward conformity, punish dissent, and manufacture the apparent consensus to which other uncertain people defer. A powerful main CPU may assist this process by producing sophisticated rationalizations for directions that the bigOther has already made emotionally compulsory.

The relation is recursive rather than simply top-down. Spellbinders gain a selection advantage in a culture whose lens rewards their methods, while their control over institutions enables them to strengthen that lens. A normopathic culture can arise without a single deliberate architect through decentralized conformity, dependency, and institutional inertia; it can then be captured by ponerological actors. Conversely, a would-be spellbinder cannot sustain a pathocracy without compatible institutions and a sufficiently synchronized population.

In this synthesis, Bonhoeffer’s **Dummheit** names a characteristic loss of inner independence on the population side; **Normopathie** names the normalization and social reproduction of that condition; and political ponerology—especially **pathocracy**—names the elite formation and power process that can cultivate and exploit it.

These terms are interpretive cross-references, not interchangeable clinical diagnoses or licenses to pathologize political opponents. Normopathie and political ponerology are not standard mainstream empirical categories, and the culture-mechanical connection proposed here should not be attributed directly to Hans-Joachim Maaz or

Andrzej M. Łobaczewski. Its claim is narrower: the concepts illuminate complementary positions within one possible cultural feedback loop.

Jaynes, Bach, and agentified collective enactment Julian Jaynes’s *The Origin of Consciousness in the Breakdown of the Bicameral Mind* and Joscha Bach’s “*Synthetic Sentience*” provide neighbouring models for two different levels of agentified enactment. Jaynes hypothesized an older mentality in which action-guiding products were experienced as the auditory commands of gods rather than as self-authored deliberation. Bach describes selves and gods as implemented agents and develops the possibility of a multi-mind-self enacted across several human minds. Culture Mechanics does not adopt either complete theory. It uses their conjunction to ask how a culturally represented agent can become locally present and distributedly operative.

Neighbouring proposal	Culture-mechanical interpretation	Boundary
Jaynesian bicameral mentality	A possible highly agentified, command-like operating regime of homo duplex	It is not a synonym for homo duplex and is not required by the architecture.
Divine auditory commands	Cultural programming experienced as bigOther-presence or bigOther-as-Thou and attributed to a god-agent	The local bigOther normally classifies affectively and need not generate auditory voices.
Commands not experienced as self-authored	Weak personal authorship, deep capture, or possible subjecthood absorption	Obedience and presence alone do not establish total fusion.
Several gods addressing one person	Several compatible divine agent-models held within one pantheonic mythological weave and activated by situation, ritual, role, or place	This need not install several local bigOthers or violate single-slot exclusivity.
Bach’s god or top-level agent implemented across minds	A distributed bigOther that may cross the threshold into collective perception, memory, judgment, intention, ownership, and action	Shared representation and synchronized devotion alone remain below the multi-mind-self threshold.
Human alignment and collective agency	Coupling, compatible programming, functional integration, and collective-agent formation	Alignment is not one scalar and does not establish truth, goodness, jurisdiction, corrigibility, or fusion.

The safe comparative formulation is:

Jaynesian bicameral mentality can be interpreted as a culturally produced, highly agentified, command-like operating mode of homo duplex in which the culturally programmed second side becomes phenomenologically present as one or more gods and receives action-guiding authority otherwise attributed to an autobiographical self.

The less historically committed name **bicameral-like enactment** refers to that possible regime without accepting Jaynes’s dating, universal scope, philology, or neurological explanation. Jaynes emphasizes intrapersonal phenomenology; Bach emphasizes distributed implementation; Culture Mechanics proposes a functional bridge:

- shared mythology of a god
- god-agent represented in local mythological lenses
- agentified Beseelung and presence as Thou
- coordinated enactment through several persons and institutions
- distributed bigOther
- possible god-as-multi-mind-self
- social confirmation of the god's local presence

The god-agent can acquire functional perception through adherents, memory through scripture and tradition, judgment through compatible local bigOthers, speech through persons and institutions, intention through ritual or decision procedures, ownership through sacred or common objects, and action through coordinated bodies. This implementation can remain differentiated. It becomes fused when the collectively enacted subject displaces participating persons as independently legitimate authors.

A pantheon is compatible with the single-slot principle when its gods are agent-personae with differentiated jurisdictions inside one operative weave. A ritual or situation can activate one persona without changing the processor. Incompatible top-level packages contesting the same load-bearing classifications still require rejection or replacement under single-slot exclusivity.

These comparisons have strict evidential limits. A [multidisciplinary critical reappraisal](#) identifies neurological and philological problems in Jaynes's proposal while treating the non-unitary self as an important legacy. Ancient texts rarely decide whether a reported god-voice was an auditory experience, ritual language, literary convention, political legitimation, or some combination. Resemblance to Jaynes or Bach therefore does not validate the local-bigOther architecture, prove a history of consciousness, reduce theological beings to human artifacts, or make every religion, ritual, shared intention, or synchronized group a multi-mind-self.

Summary cross-reference table

Related concept	Primary question	Relation to culture mechanics
Autonomous mind	What fast default response is generated?	Part of the ordinary brain and elephant, not the bigOther; the collar can alter its affective inputs and direction.
Algorithmic mind	Is there sufficient computational capacity?	Corresponds most closely to the processing power of the main CPU.
Reflective mind	Will reflective processing be initiated, and under which goals and dispositions?	Corresponds to the CPU's governing and self-corrective activity, represented partly by the rider.
Cognitive miserliness	Was reflective processing avoided?	The CPU accepts an easy response without inspecting the elephant or collar.
Override failure	Was a detected default unsuccessfully suppressed?	The CPU engages but fails to overcome a strongly weighted elephant or bigOther response.
Mindware gap	Is a rational tool missing?	The main CPU lacks the learned rule needed to construct a corrective response.
Contaminated mindware	Has acquired mindware corrupted rational judgment?	For culture mechanics, this is a bigOther executing a defective mythological lens that uses strong sentiments and evaluation-disabling rules to steer the CPU away from epistemic or instrumental rationality.
Dysrationalia	Why can adequate intelligence coexist with irrationality?	The bigOther is one possible source of direction or inhibition independent of CPU power.
Motivated reasoning	How do desired conclusions bias reasoning?	The main CPU reasons directionally under affective priorities that the bigOther may supply.
Identity-protective cognition	How does group identity bias judgment?	The wireless collar attaches belonging, status, and exclusion to conclusions.
Sacred values and taboo trade-offs	Which comparisons are morally prohibited?	The bigOther determines what may not be questioned, priced, or compromised.
Actively open-minded thinking	Can the person seek disconfirmation and revise?	Healthy mindware helps the main CPU inspect the bigOther's output.
Master signifier	Which symbol organizes a field of meaning?	A highly compressed protocol token can activate a cluster of mythologies and mappings already present in the mythological lens.

Related concept	Primary question	Relation to culture mechanics
Bonhoefferian Dummheit	How does social power displace inner independence?	Describes large-scale capture of judgment by a power-saturated bigOther.
Normopathie	How does a population adapt to and reproduce a pathological normality?	Describes the population-side condition in which a captured bigOther supplies borrowed judgment, conformity, and distributed enforcement.
Political ponerology / pathocracy	How do destructive actors form, capture, and exploit political power?	Describes the elite-side actors and selection processes that can program, administer, and profit from a captured distributed bigOther.
Jaynesian bicameral mentality	How might culturally generated guidance be experienced as the commands of gods rather than self-authored thought?	Supplies a controversial intrapersonal limit model for agentified, command-like homo duplex; it does not define the ordinary local bigOther.
Bachian god-as-multi-mind-self	How might one represented agent be implemented across several minds and bodies?	Supplies a distributed-agent neighbour; Culture Mechanics adds its local processor, field formation, functional threshold, fusion axis, and metaphysical boundary.

20. Scope and terminological cautions

Culture mechanics is a proposed synthetic term, not the established name of a single accepted scientific theory. It combines ideas associated with social psychology, Durkheimian sociology, Lacanian psychoanalysis, Systems Leadership, narrative theory, cybernetics, distributed cognition, cultural evolution, and systems theory.

Its computer and wireless-collar descriptions are functional models, not claims that the brain literally contains a PCI card or a separately identifiable anatomical collar processor. Its charged-particle, field, laser, wireless, and computing comparisons describe proposed relations and generate hypotheses; they do not assert that social processes are physically electromagnetic or obey the equations of the source domains.

Its use of **homo duplex** extends Durkheim. Its use of **bigOther** operationalizes and modifies Lacan. Its protocol interpretation isolates one functional aspect of Lacan's symbolic order rather than exhausting the concept. **bigOther-presence** and **bigOther-as-Thou** borrow phenomenological cues from James and Buber without attributing the proposed processor or field mechanism to either thinker. These inherited terms name important sources of the model but should not be mistaken for exact summaries of their doctrines.

Relevant structure and the underlying connection between experienced moral good or evil and represented structural support or damage are adapted from Dushan Wegner's *Relevante Strukturen*. The typed relational definition, the separation of felt relevance, represented effect, actual effect, generative centrality, and normative standing, the multidimensional account of strengthening, and the placement of the appraisal inside the homo-duplex and single-slot architecture are Culture Mechanics extensions. They should not be attributed to Wegner as his own distinctions. The named change-indexed moral-mobilization hypothesis is likewise a project-developed operationalization of Wegner's emphasis on change, not his own formal construct.

Jaynes's bicameral mind and Bach's implemented multi-mind-self are neighbouring theories, not analogies or empirical confirmation. The term *multi-mind-self* in this project is taken from Bach and given the explicit functional threshold stated above. The bicameral-like comparison is narrower than Jaynes's historical theory and must not be used to claim that ancient people universally lacked consciousness or an individual mind.

The theory's three constitutive commitments each carry an explanatory burden. The local bigOther is functionally distinct from the main CPU; the distributed field is emergent from relations among persons, communications, institutions, practices, and artifacts; and the single-slot principle permits a modular weave of compatible packages while denying parallel operative evaluators. Under the third commitment, first-order and lifted programming both fully occupy the slot; order level distinguishes shared concrete answers from a shared generator of answers; a lifted generator may govern universally while constituting limited subordinate jurisdictions; and corrigibility must be

evaluated independently. These claims should produce comparative explanations and possible tests. None licenses an immaterial substance, erases the responsibility and causal contribution of biological persons, or proves that every apparent conflict of allegiance is a completed worldview replacement.

The single-slot commitment is therefore defeasible in principle. A stable case of two incompatible evaluators remaining independently final over the same conduct, each generating its own affect, veto, and correction without hierarchy, reinterpretation, contextual division, or a third governing rule, would count against it. This defeat condition should not be neutralized after the fact by calling every such observation a complex braid.

The framework also does not claim that cultural programming determines behaviour mechanically. Humans interpret, combine, resist, conceal, question, and change symbolic instructions. The model proposes structured influence, not perfect control.

Culture-mechanical object, ideological symbol, conformity signal, targeting signal, the four propagation and enforcement forms, **jealous cultural program, enforcement–exclusion duality, protection-framed jurisdictional manoeuvre**, and the combined signal–moralization–jurisdiction mechanism are project-developed constructs. The four forms are ideal types rather than a validated scale. Andrick supplies the theory of moralization attributed to him; the processor, protocol, field, jealousy, and ideology-as-hallucination extensions belong to Culture Mechanics. Whole religion classifications and the Iran end-state claim are explicit hypotheses, not facts established by the definitions themselves. [Gregory H. Stanton](#) supplies the neighbouring genocidal-process model attributed to him, not the targeting-signal definition or the culture-mechanical causal ontology.

An observed symbol does not by itself disclose the carrier's private intention, degree of belief, or complete program. The same token can be voluntary, coerced, devotional, propagating, targeting, jurisdictional, resistant, or multiply functional in different settings. Target status can be made legible through performance, absence, imposition, or attribution. The relevant evidence includes who is expected to perform the token, who assigns it, who may refuse, how absence is interpreted, what sanctions follow, which jurisdiction is claimed, and what the program does after acquiring power.

Finally, describing culture as programming does not imply that all symbolic reality is false. Money, law, office, obligation, legitimacy, and dignity are symbolically constituted but socially consequential realities. Culture mechanics distinguishes such constitutive social meanings from factual claims about physical reality, which remain answerable to evidence.

Semantic summary

- **Broader class:** theory of cultural causation and social coordination.
- **Central object:** the culturally programmed bigOther in the homo-duplex individual.
- **Primary operation:** sentiment classification.
- **Narrative unit:** one mythology—one socially evaluated narrative or story; *narrative* is the broader ordinary-language term and often its fuzzy synonym.
- **Narrative corpus:** mythologies—the accumulated stories that train cultural evaluation.
- **Installed evaluative program:** the mythological lens shaped by those mythologies and reinforced by systems, symbols, practices, and institutions.
- **Relevant structure:** a represented relational arrangement or organized condition that the installed lens treats as carrying moral weight.
- **Relevant-structure appraisal hypothesis:** people often experience represented support for a felt-relevant structure as good and represented damage as evil; felt relevance, represented effect, actual effect, generative centrality, and normative standing remain distinct.
- **Generative-centrality distinction:** a structure can causally produce capabilities required by many downstream structures without receiving corresponding felt relevance; a cultural sublimation architecture is one proposed case.
- **Change-indexed moral-mobilization hypothesis:** moral appraisal often becomes more salient and action-directing when a condition is represented as causing, continuing, preventing, or failing to prevent change in a felt-relevant structure; this is a testable mobilization pathway, not a complete ontology of ethics.
- **Analytical umbrella:** a culture-mechanical object is a program, carrier, implementation arrangement, processor state, collective formation, or collective agent involved in cultural installation, activation, transmission, execution, synchronization, or enforcement; its subtype must be identified.
- **Religion-inclusive program category:** religions, secular ideologies, company cultures, activist movements, professional cultures, and state programmes are analyzed as members of the same broad family rather than different ontological kinds.

- **Ideological symbol:** a medium-independent socially legible token that activates an installed program and communicates a person's relation to it.
- **Conformity signal:** an ideological symbol whose performance, absence, refusal, or substitution makes conformity and deviation publicly legible.
- **Targeting signal:** a performed, omitted, imposed, or attributed socially legible token that assigns a person or population to a sanctionable out-group; an absent conformity signal can therefore become a target marker.
- **Propagation and enforcement forms:** private, collective, ideological form, and fundamentalist; these are ideal-type program configurations, not kinds of bigOther or one necessary developmental staircase.
- **Conflict ladder:** propositional, causal-story, and classification conflicts remain distinct from mythological rivalry; active interference creates mythological conflict, incompatible governing lenses create cultural-program conflict, organized recruitment and suppression create ideological-form conflict, and physical coercion or violence marks fundamentalist-form conflict.
- **Signal-suppression distinction:** rival-signal or counter-program suppression describes interference with opposition without analytically reducing rival or corrective signals to random noise.
- **Independent animation axis:** *Beseelung* describes how affectively alive and conduct-directing a program is, independently of its propagation or violence.
- **Jealous cultural program:** a program that claims exclusive allegiance and treats incompatible commitment, dissent, or exit as betrayal; single-slot exclusivity alone is not jealousy.
- **Moralized enforcement bridge:** a signal or refusal becomes character disclosure, character accusation attacks civic or social standing, solidarity distributes the judgment, and systems attach exclusion or coercion.
- **Enforcement-exclusion duality:** enforcement conditions continued inclusion, standing, access, or permitted action on conformity; exclusion is the withdrawal or denial applied to refusal, and one visible sanction can perform both operations.
- **Fundamentalist threshold:** authorization or willingness to use physical or eliminative force, not the mere presence of moral evaluation or discursive violence.
- **Genocidal escalation neighbour:** Stanton's ten overlapping processes map one possible path from classification and symbolization through discrimination, dehumanization, organization, polarization, preparation, persecution, and extermination to denial; they are not a universal ladder or a synonym for the broader culture-mechanical repertoire.
- **Local processor:** the bigOther that executes the lens.
- **Single-slot constraint:** one local bigOther executes one operative lens; no higher runtime evaluator ranks parallel bigOthers or governing worldviews.
- **Complete slot occupancy / full capture:** a stable first-order or lifted program completely occupies the one slot; *full* does not by itself mean pathological.
- **Order levels:** first-order mechanical solidarity shares concrete rules and answers; lifted mechanical solidarity shares rules that generate, select, apply, and revise concrete answers.
- **Generative relation:** fixed, installed meta-rules combine with current knowledge or inputs and a situation to generate a binding first-order output; generator and output remain parts of one weave.
- **Jurisdictional distinction:** a lifted meta-order may govern universally at its own level while persons, offices, institutions, communities, and contracting parties remain plural and domain-limited beneath it; that pluralism is a consequence or application, not the definition of lifting.
- **Corrigibility axis:** first-order and lifted captures can each be open or closed; epistemic sovereignty, correction failure, interpretive monopoly, and jurisdictional spillover—not rivalry alone—mark pathology.
- **Package compositionality:** compatible religious, professional, familial, national, and local packages can be braided into that one complex lens.
- **Replacement under incompatibility:** an incompatible governing program must be rejected, or the incumbent weave must be unbraided sufficiently for one successor to be rebraided and installed.
- **Three-layer causal distinction:** the historical cause of a rule, its current affective classification, and its presently avowed reason can coincide or diverge and should be measured separately.
- **Formation-construction distinction:** endogenous mythology formation is the distributed growth and selection of cultural articulations from changing conditions and a substantive research path in its own right; purposive mythology construction is the prospective study of attempted target-state-guided intervention in that same ecology.
- **Intervention-hypothesis boundary:** mythology may be a privileged symbolic intervention surface, but it is not the whole culture-implementation stack; attempted purposive construction neither places the constructor outside culture nor guarantees the installed successor.
- **Single-slot defeat condition:** stable same-domain operation by two incompatible evaluators that remain independently final, affectively alive, and mutually ungoverned would count against strict single-slot exclusivity.
- **Phenomenological appearance:** bigOther-presence or bigOther-as-Thou—the collective or symbolic authority

encountered as an objectively present Other.

- **Agentified enactment depth:** representation, consultation or service, presence as Thou, distributed enactment, and fused enactment must not be collapsed; only the final relation entails authorial displacement.
- **Immediate target:** the elephant—the intuitive, motivational, largely nonconscious mind.
- **Conscious interface:** the rider and the main CPU.
- **Shared communication interface:** Lacan's big Other, functionally translated as the on-the-wire symbolic protocol.
- **Network operation:** reciprocal signalling through the protocol and possible synchronization.
- **Field coherence:** mechanical solidarity.
- **Emergent network state:** the distributed bigOther.
- **Possible collective agent:** the multi-mind-self when integration and continuity pass the relevant threshold.
- **Nested authorship:** a network-level multi-mind-self can add an operative we while differentiated participating /s retain legitimate personal and subordinate jurisdictions; it does not install a second local bigOther.
- **Episodic multi-mind-self:** a distributed bigOther that crosses the collective-agent threshold only during bounded high-integration periods; viable latency, de-animation, and cultural loss remain different inter-episode states.
- **Differentiated unity:** a real shared we that preserves distinct persons, functions, judgments, relationships, and legitimate subordinate jurisdictions; **person-preserving unity** emphasizes this boundary.
- **Subjecthood absorption (fusion):** the independent extent to which a collective program denies personal judgment, conscience, purpose, property, loyalty, identity, relationships, refusal, or exit legitimate standing against the collective.
- **Fusion pressure:** dynamics that generalize compulsory alignment, subordinate differentiated jurisdictions, and weaken correction, refusal, exit, and appeal.
- **Total fusion:** the limiting combination of high subjecthood absorption, comprehensive jurisdiction, and closed correction or exit.
- **Fusion ideology:** a program that construes separate persons as alienated or falsely conscious fragments to be reconstituted as organs of one collective subject.
- **Long-term result:** reproduction or transformation of culture through ritual and institutionalization.
- **Central normative problem:** whether the bigOther remains contestable by reflective judgment or acquires final authority over it.
- **Developmental axis:** externally enforced → socially authored → self-authored → self-transforming bigOther.

Example of use

From the perspective of **culture mechanics**, the ceremony did not merely communicate the organization's values. It reenacted and reinforced particular mythologies, strengthened corresponding mappings in each participant's mythological lens, and made the bigOthers' resulting sentiments collectively observable.

Compact formulas

Single-slot composition and replacement:

one PCI slot → one local bigOther → one operative mythological lens; compatible packages → one braided program; incompatible governing worldview → rejection or incumbent unbraiding → liminal interval → one rebraided successor

Historical explanation and present execution:

historical cause ≠ live affective classification ≠ avowed reason; present agreement among them is an empirical question

Formation, intervention, and selection:

endogenous formation: changing conditions → mismatch → articulation → distributed selection → embodiment; prospective purposive construction: candidate chosen destination D* → diagnosis → symbolic and institutional intervention → testing and correction; where intervention is attempted, the actual successor is jointly constrained by intention, receivers, incumbent and rival fields, institutions, consequences, and reality

Relevant-structure appraisal:

felt relevance × represented support or damage → possible moral appraisal and mobilization; actual multidimensional effect + generative centrality + normative standing → separate evaluation

Sublimation-bearing symbols and lens programming:

carrier or activation device → installed sublimation-related mappings → local-bigOther classification; repeated rival mythology + systems + rewards + sanctions + conduct → possible lens reprogramming → changed Beseelung, enactment, and transmission

Change-indexed moral mobilization:

represented change, continuation, prevention, or culpable omission affecting felt-relevant structure → intensified moral classification and action readiness (hypothesis, not definition)

Single-slot hard test:

two incompatible same-domain evaluators + independent finality + independent affect, veto, and correction + stable coexistence without hierarchy, reinterpretation, contextual division, or third rule → evidence against strict single-slot exclusivity

Order, jurisdiction, and lifting:

one fully occupied slot × {shared concrete rules and answers | shared answer-generating meta-rules} × {corrigible | pathological}; fixed M + current K_t + situation C → binding R_t(C); lifting may enable plural first-order outputs and bounded jurisdictions without creating a second bigOther

Person–collective constitution:

collective agency × subjecthood absorption × jurisdiction × corrigibility; differentiated unity preserves personal and subordinate standing, while generalized compulsory alignment + jurisdictional absorption + blocked correction, refusal, and exit → fusion pressure → possible total fusion

Agentified enactment and the Jaynes–Bach bridge:

mythology → god-agent represented in one operative lens → agentified Beseelung / bigOther-as-Thou → distributed enactment → possible multi-mind-self; displacement of personal authorship → fusion

Conformity and targeting signals, moralization, and enforcement–exclusion:

ideological program → performed, omitted, imposed, or attributed token → conformity, refusal, or target status becomes observable → character disclosure and accusation → distributed judgment → enforcement through inclusion, exclusion, coercion, or violence → defence or expansion of jurisdiction

Rivalry and conflict:

propositional, causal-story, or classification conflict → possible mythological rivalry → active interference with transmission, authority, membership, or institutional embodiment → mythological conflict → organized recruitment and rival-signal suppression → ideological-form conflict → physical coercion or violence → fundamentalist-form conflict

Full culture-mechanical cycle:

mythologies shape the mythological lens → the local bigOther maps observations onto social feelings → the elephant moves → the rider explains or questions → behaviour is encoded in the shared symbolic protocol → other local bigOthers classify and respond → an emergent field acts back upon its participants → distributed synchronization reproduces or transforms culture